# Demographic Transitions

Soc 170 Lecture 1.4

1/29/26

# Two Theories:

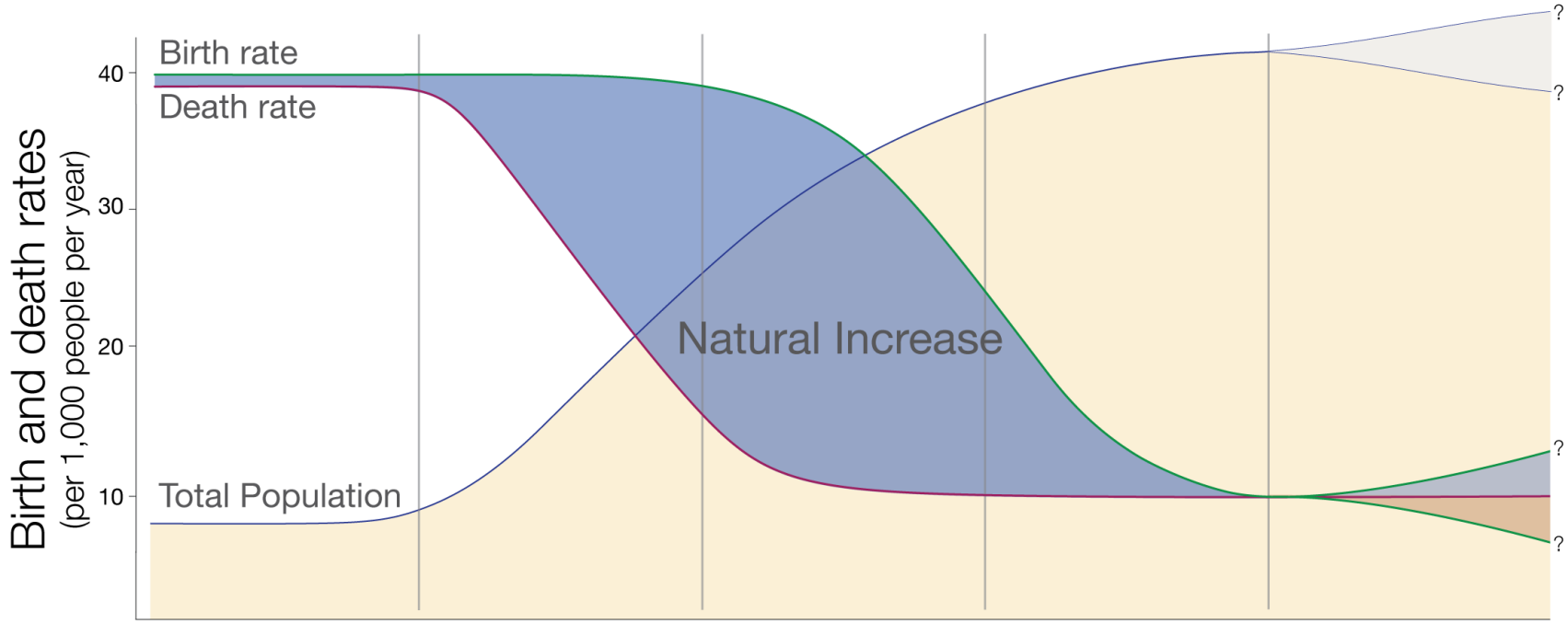
- First Demographic Transition (relatively settled)
- Second Demographic Transition (more debate)

# Premodern population beliefs

High fertility + High mortality -- “Childhood” didn’t really exist

# The five stages of the demographic transition

The demographic transition is a model that describes why rapid population growth is a temporary phenomenon.

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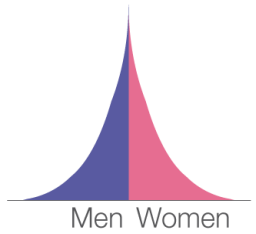
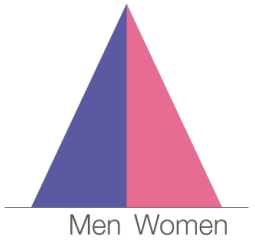
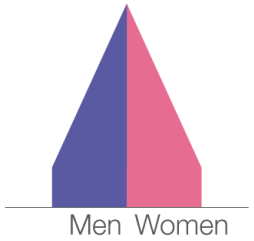
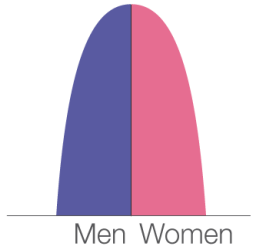
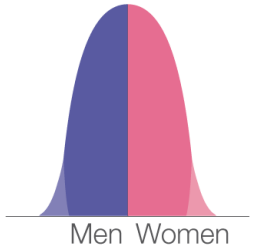
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

# The five stages of the demographic transition

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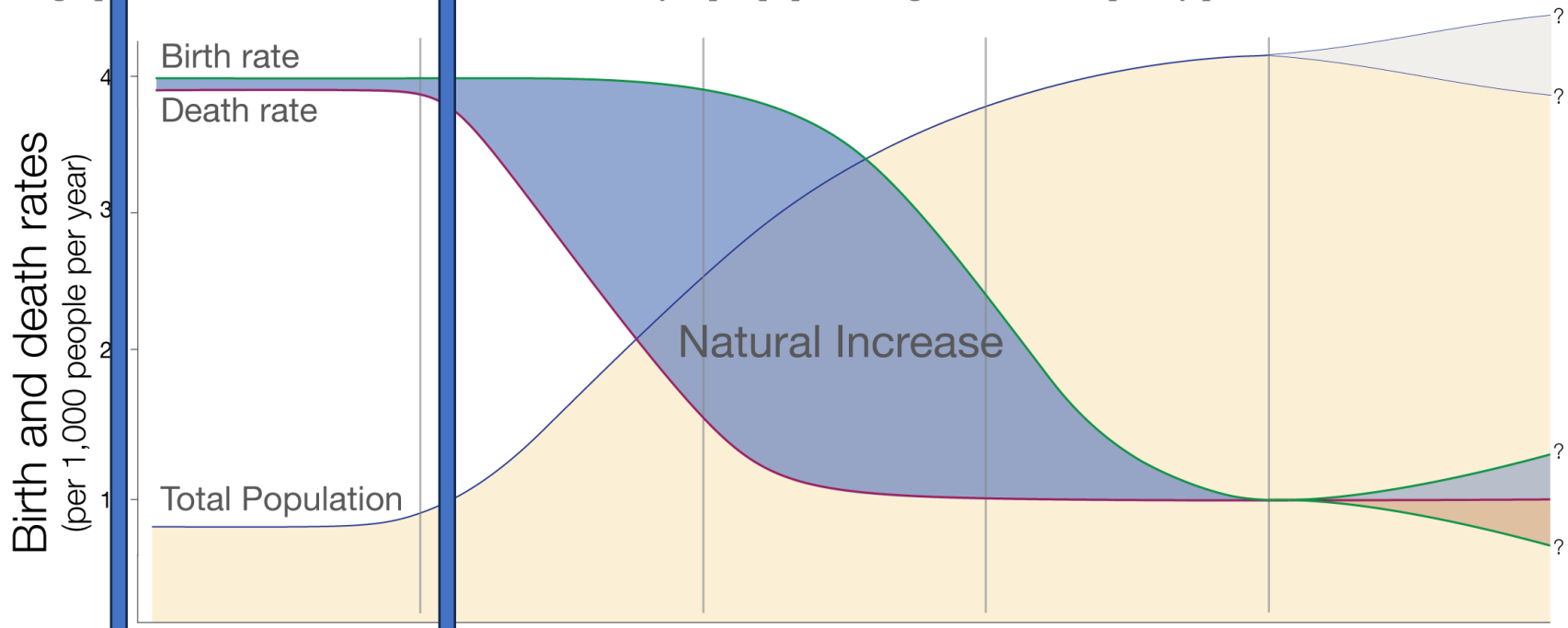


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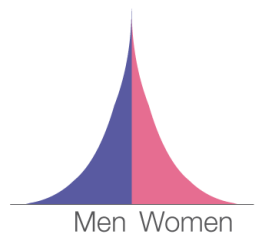
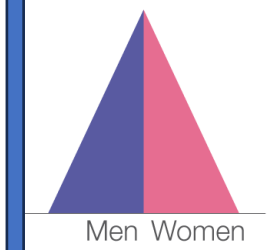
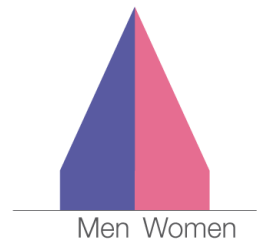
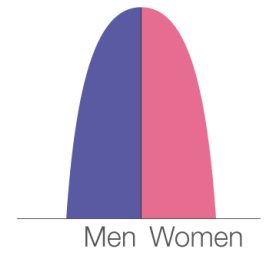
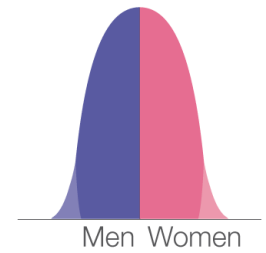
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

Mortality falls (b/c of health improvements)

But birth rates still high

# The five stages of the demographic transition

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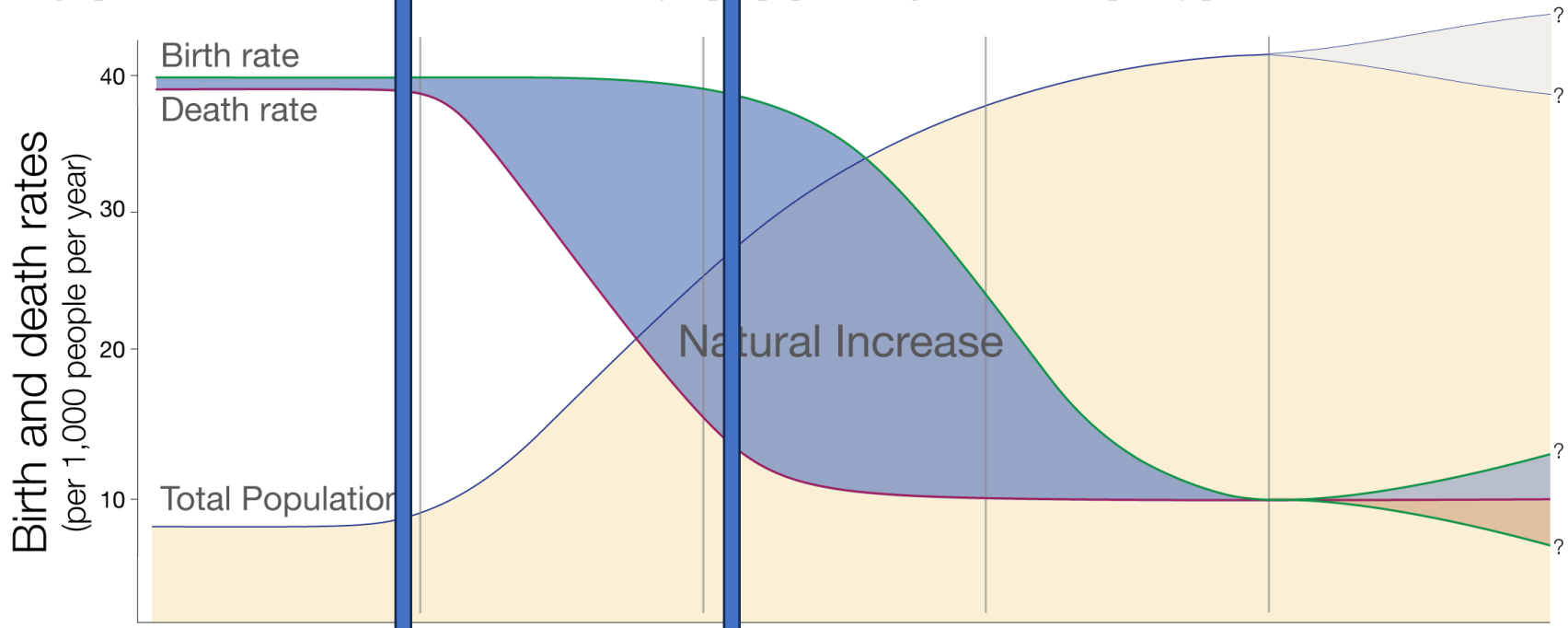


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| Population Pyramid | Men Women | Men Women | Men Women | Men Women | Men Women |

# Enlightenment

World population ~doubled from 1500-1800 after being steady for a long time

Reduction in child mortality, recognition of children + childhood as special category of humanity

Families no longer need to have as many children to hope that some survive

Becomes more advantageous to invest time + resources in fewer kids!

So fertility falls too

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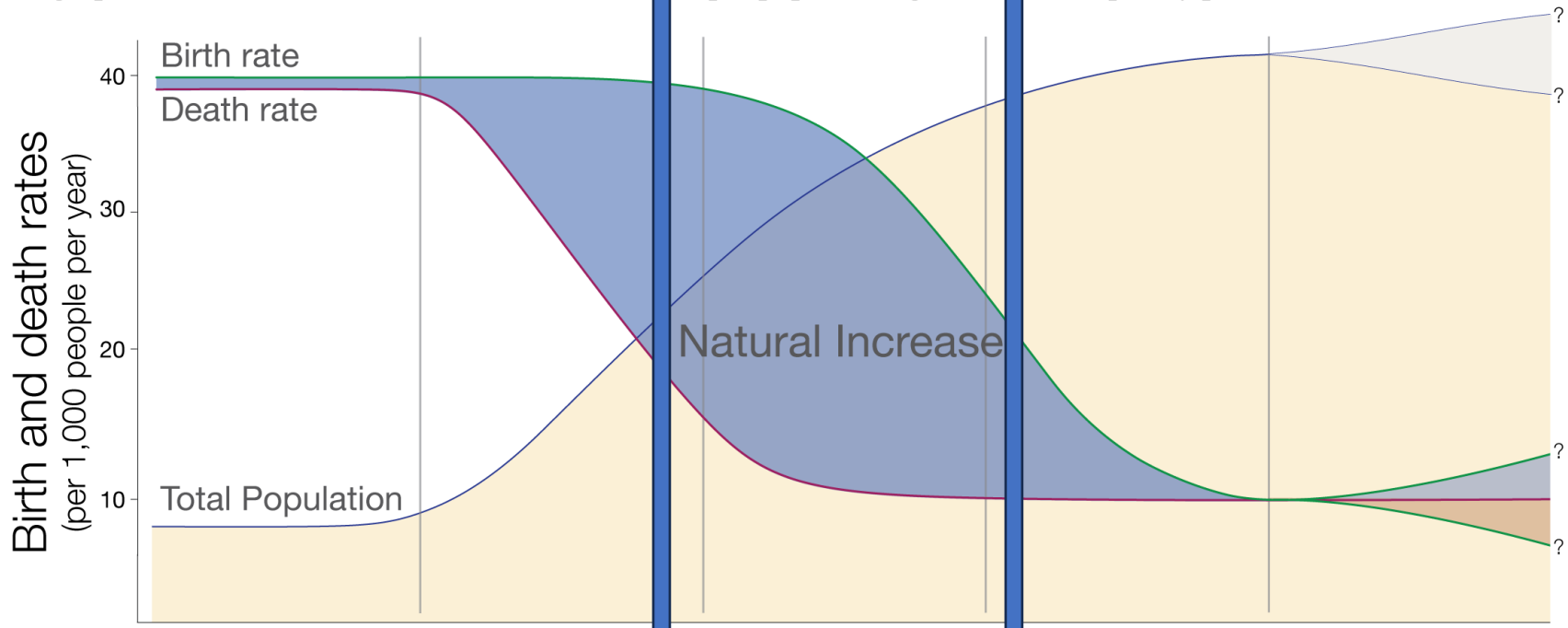


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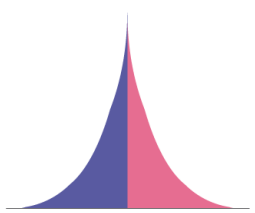
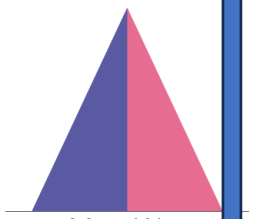
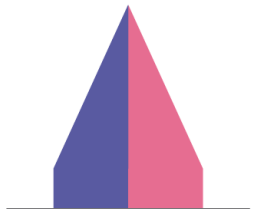
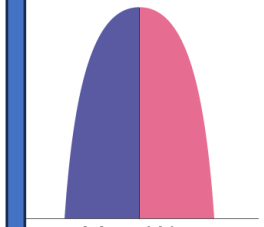
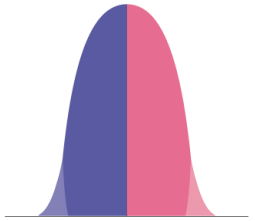
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

At some point it reaches a balance –

People generally want ~2 kids

# The five stages of the demographic transition

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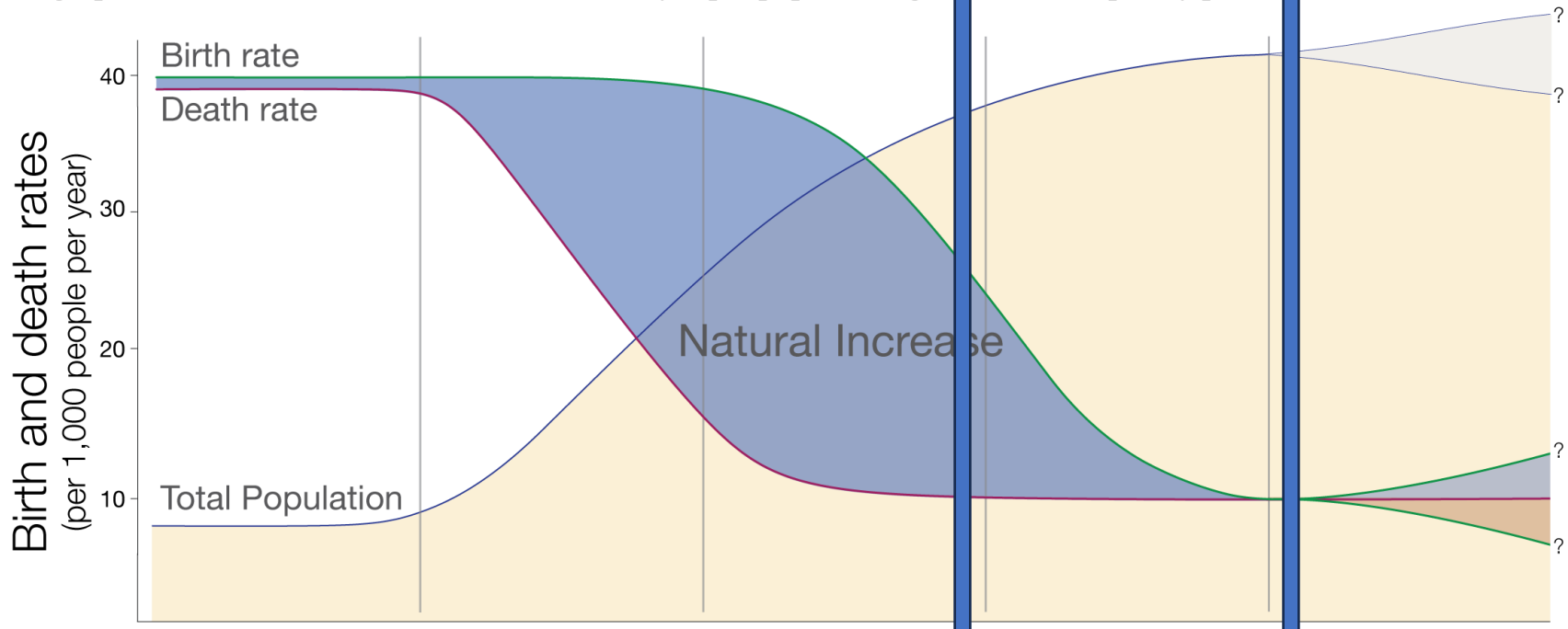


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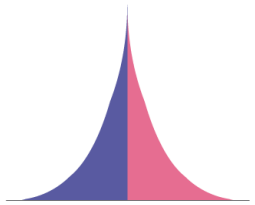
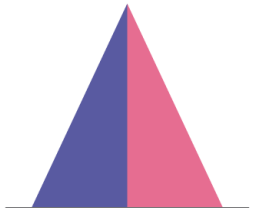
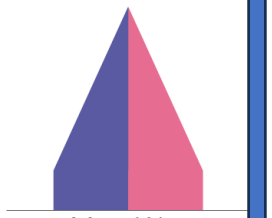
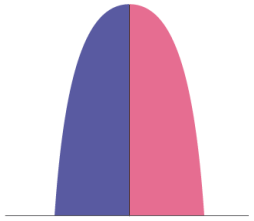
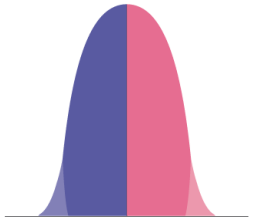
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

Men Women

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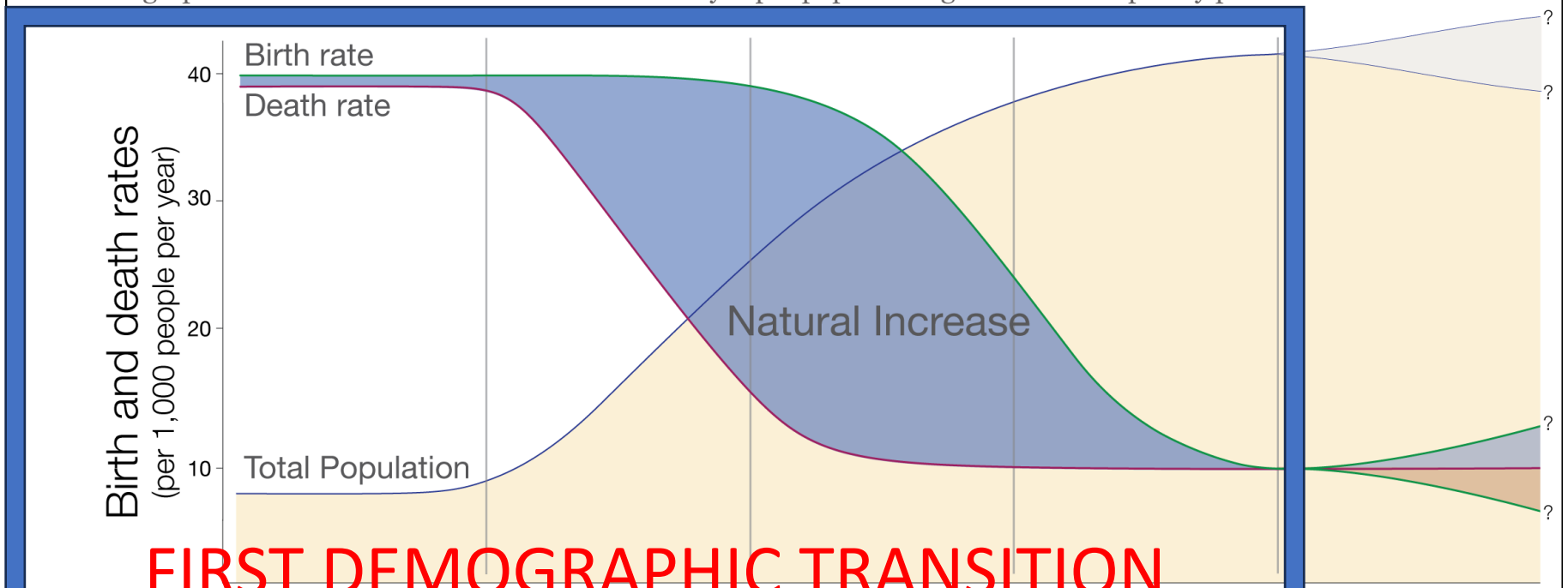


FIRST DEMOGRAPHIC TRANSITION

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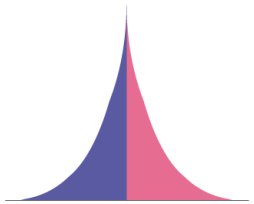
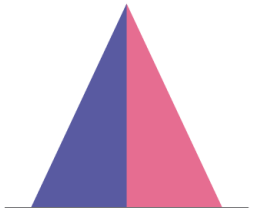
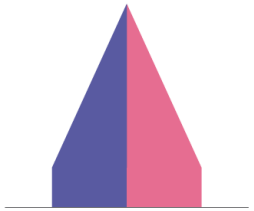
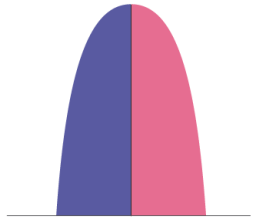
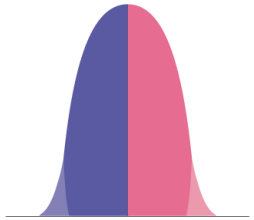
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

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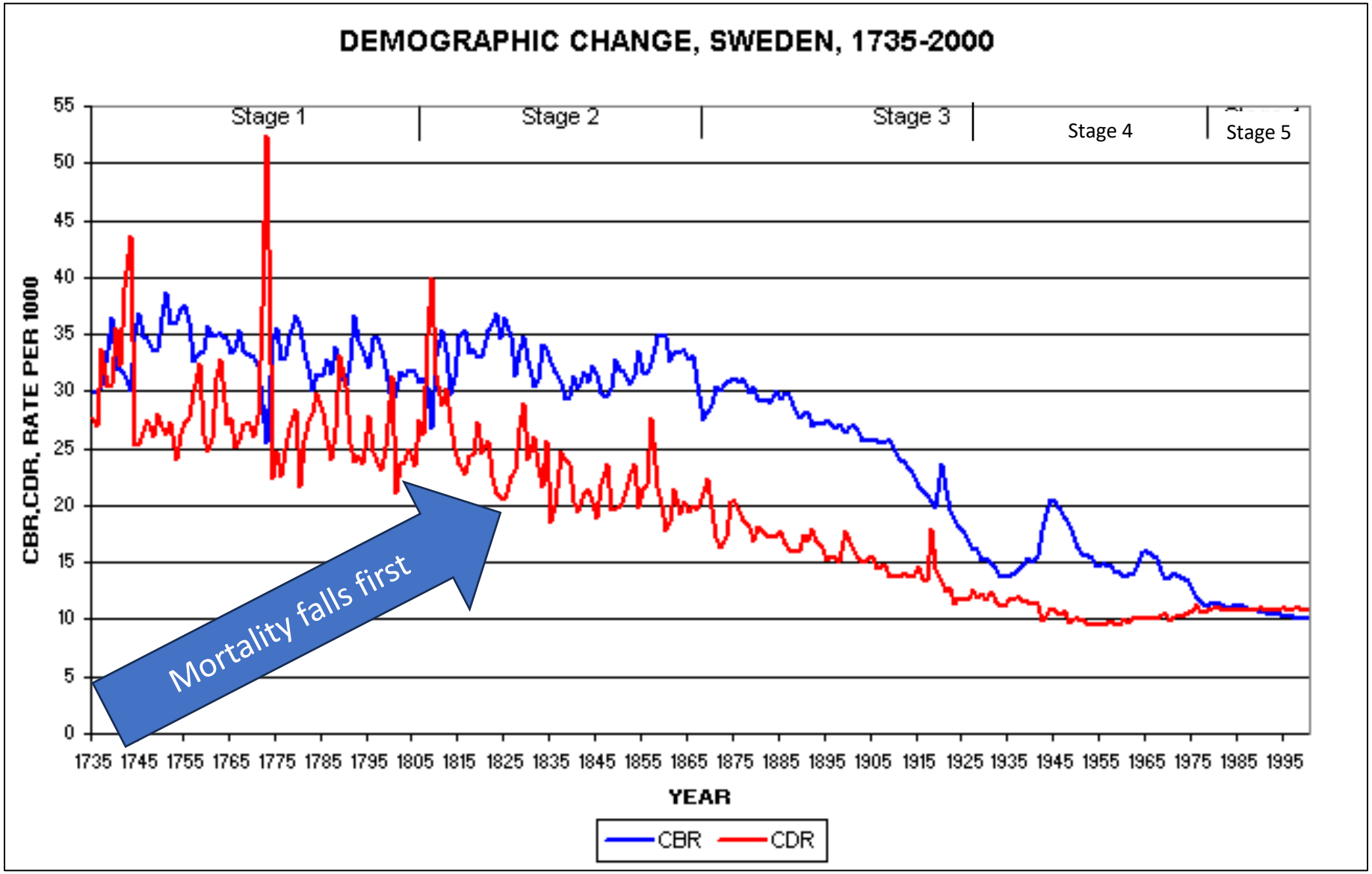
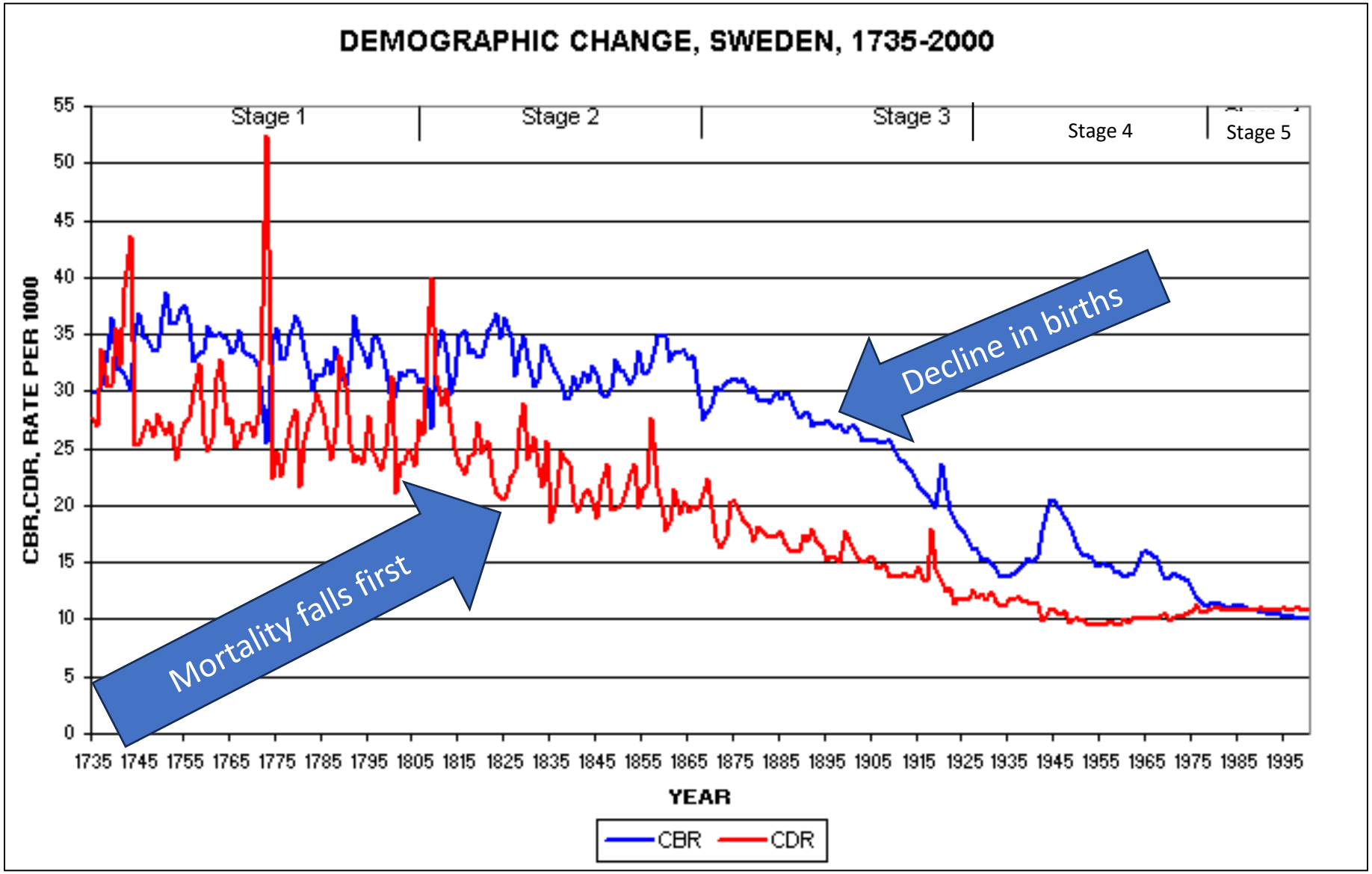



SOURCE: Keith Montgomery, http://www.uwmc.uwc.edu/geography/Demotrans/demtran.htm

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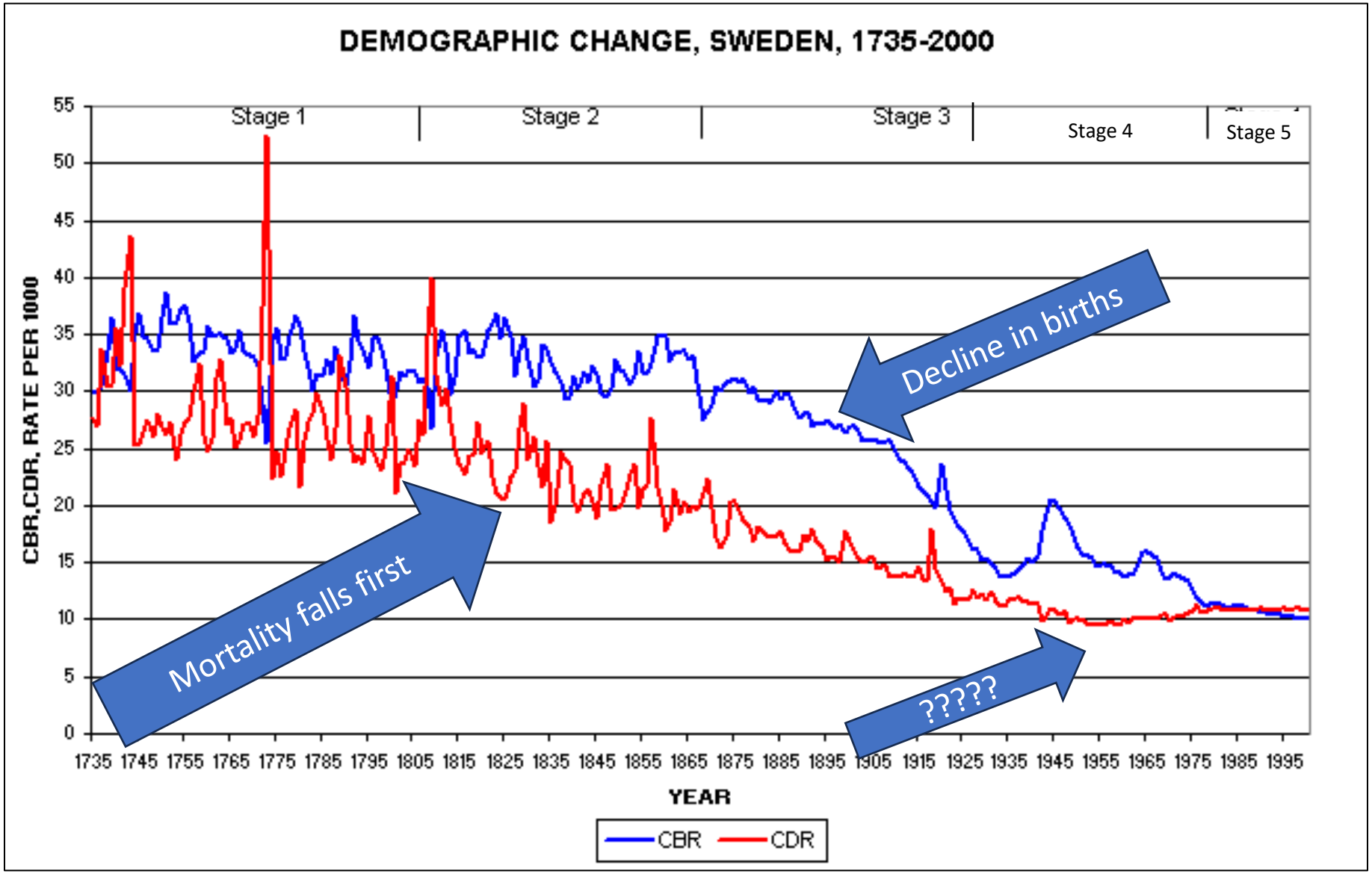


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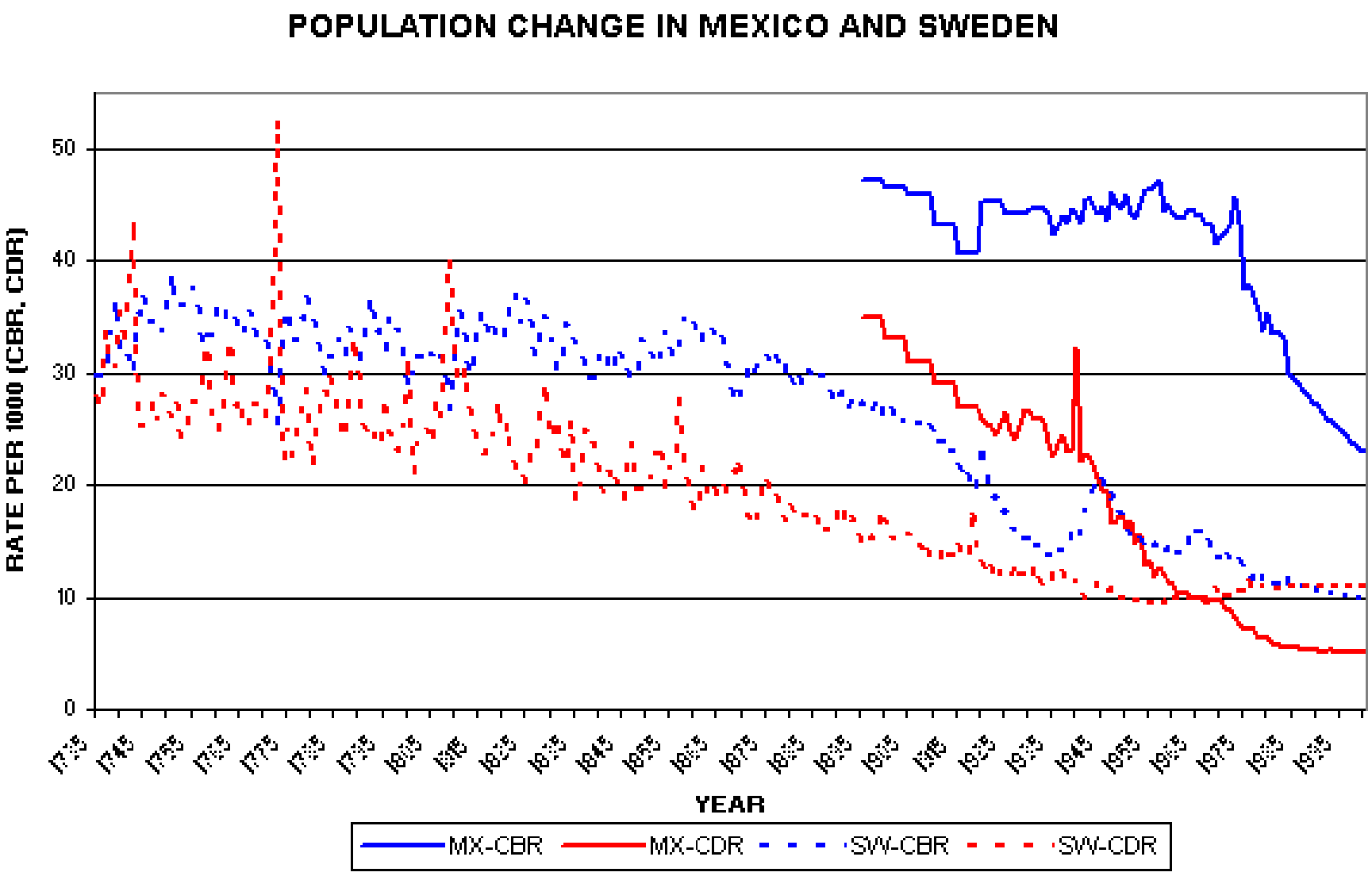


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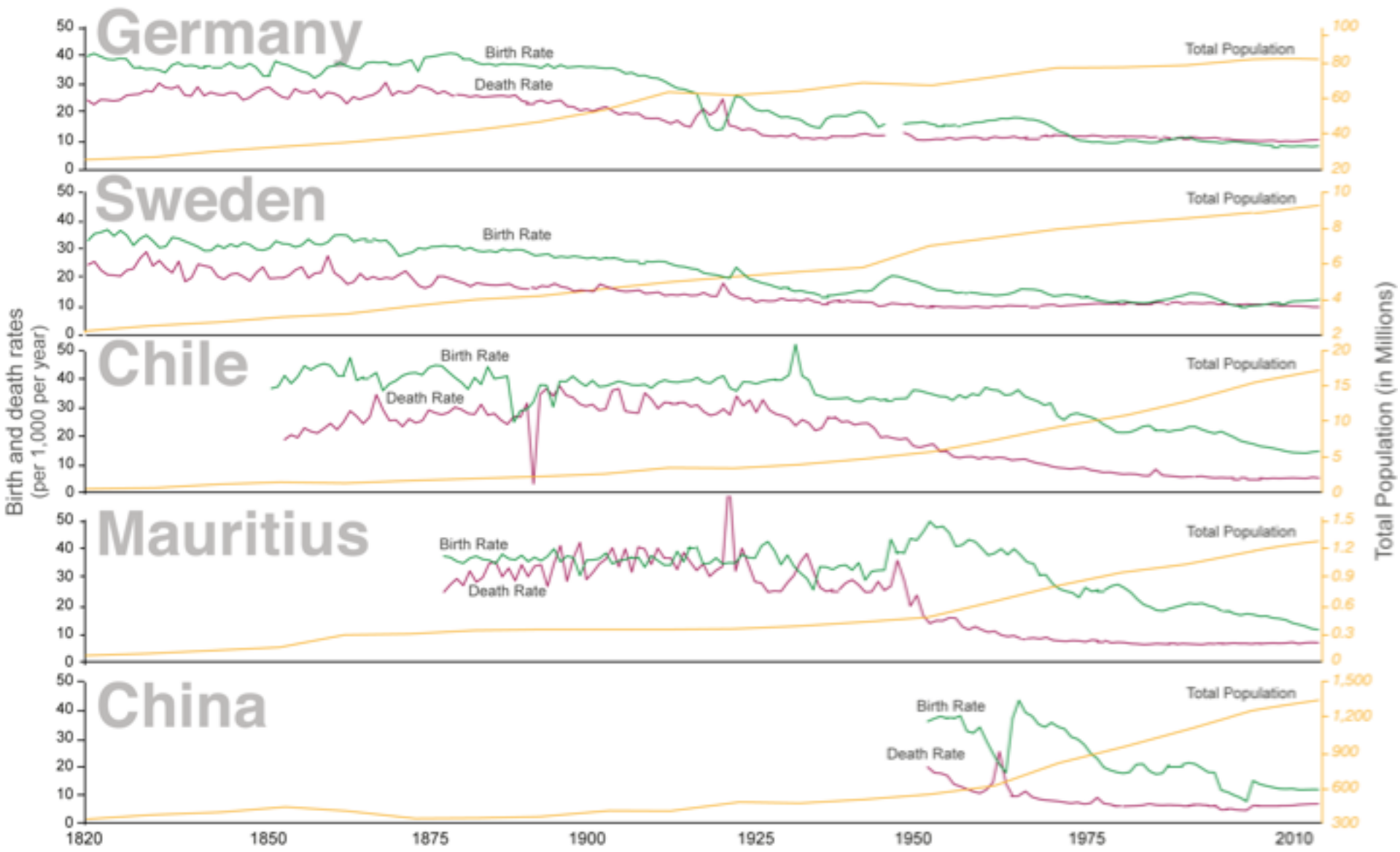
Our World in Data

# The Demographic Transition in 5 Countries

The Demographic Transition refers to the transition from high birth & death rates to low birth & death rates.
It is shown here for five countries that achieved the transition one after the other.




Data source: The data on birth rates, death rates and the total population are taken from the International Historical Statistics, edited by Palgrave Macmillan (April 2013).

The interactive data visualisation is available at OurWorldinData.org. There you find the raw data and more visualisations on this topic.

Licensed under CC-BY-SA by the author Max Roser.

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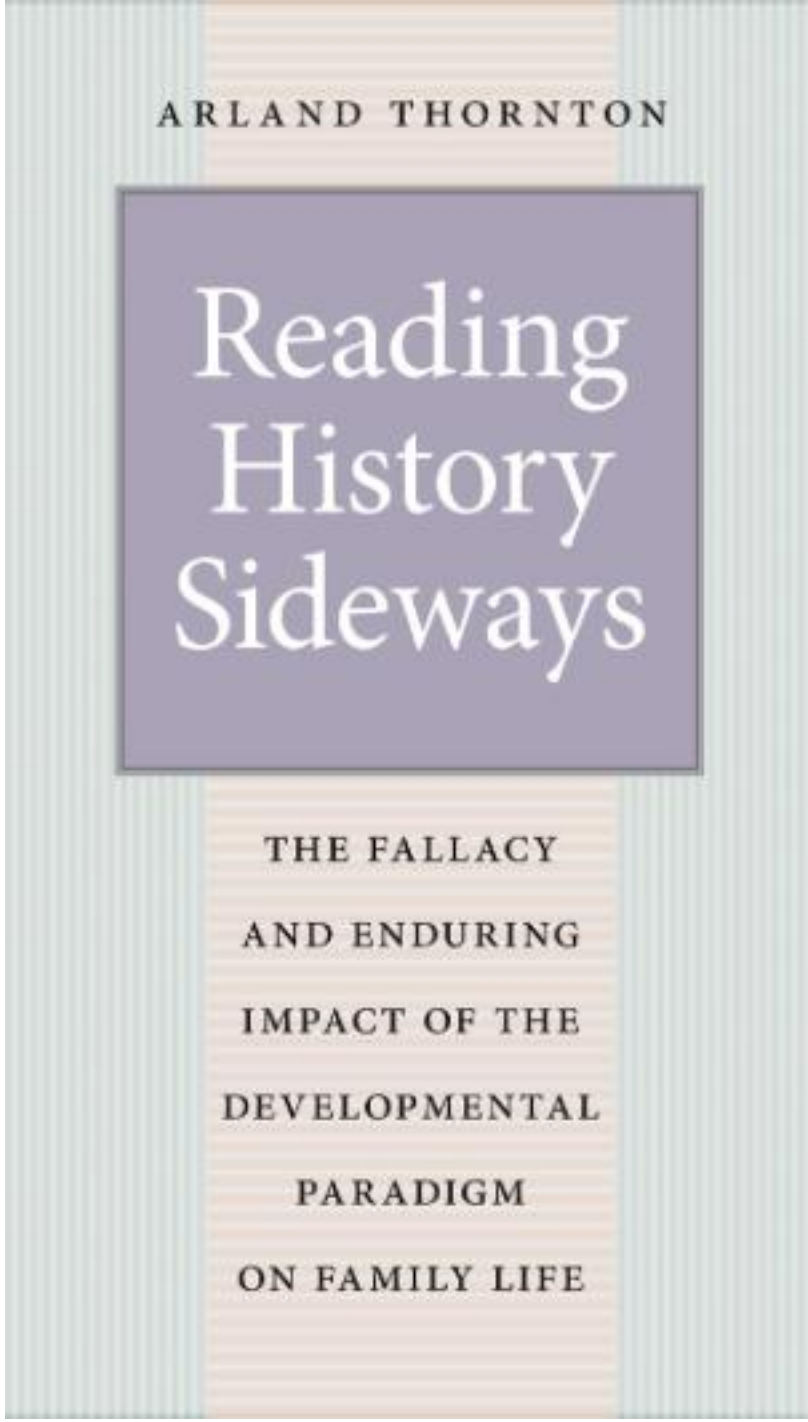

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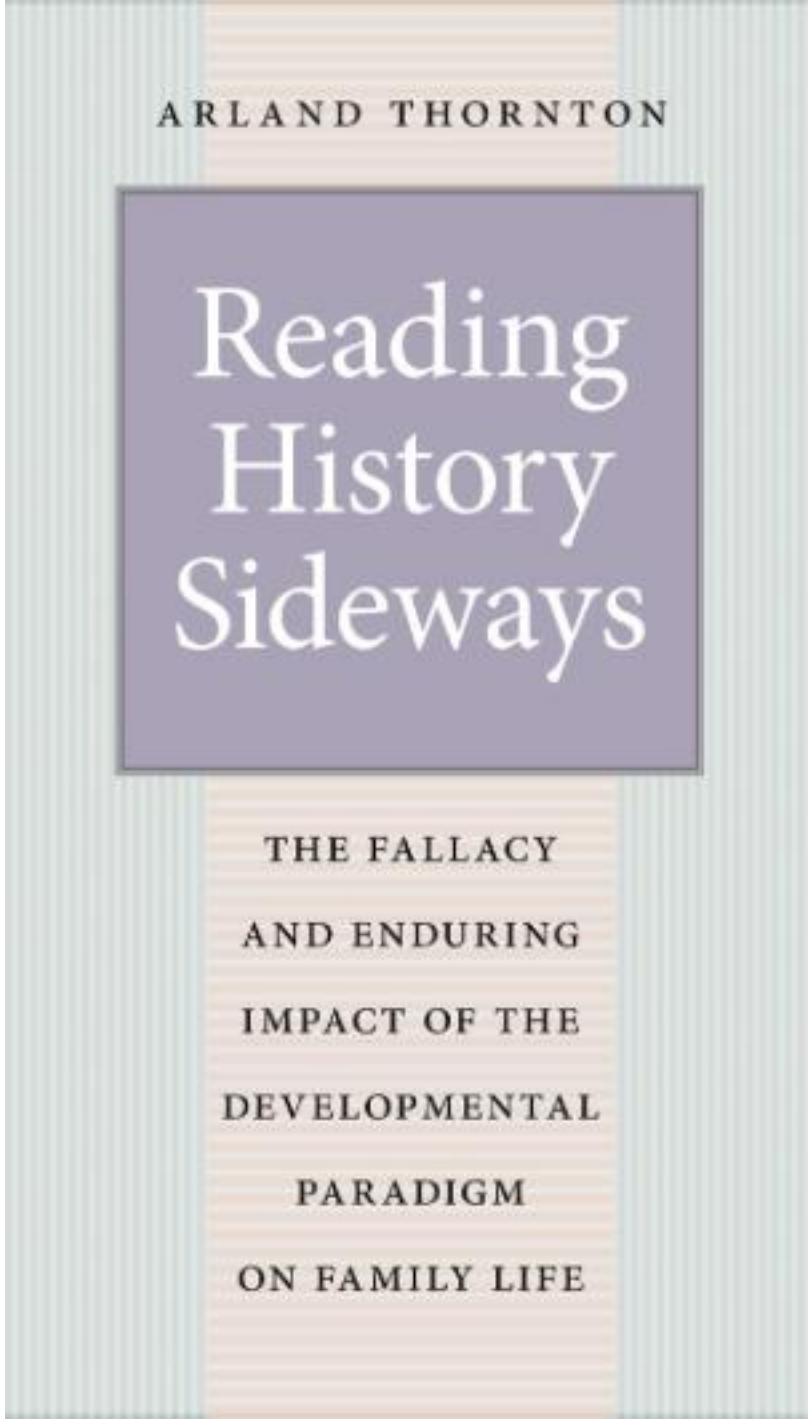

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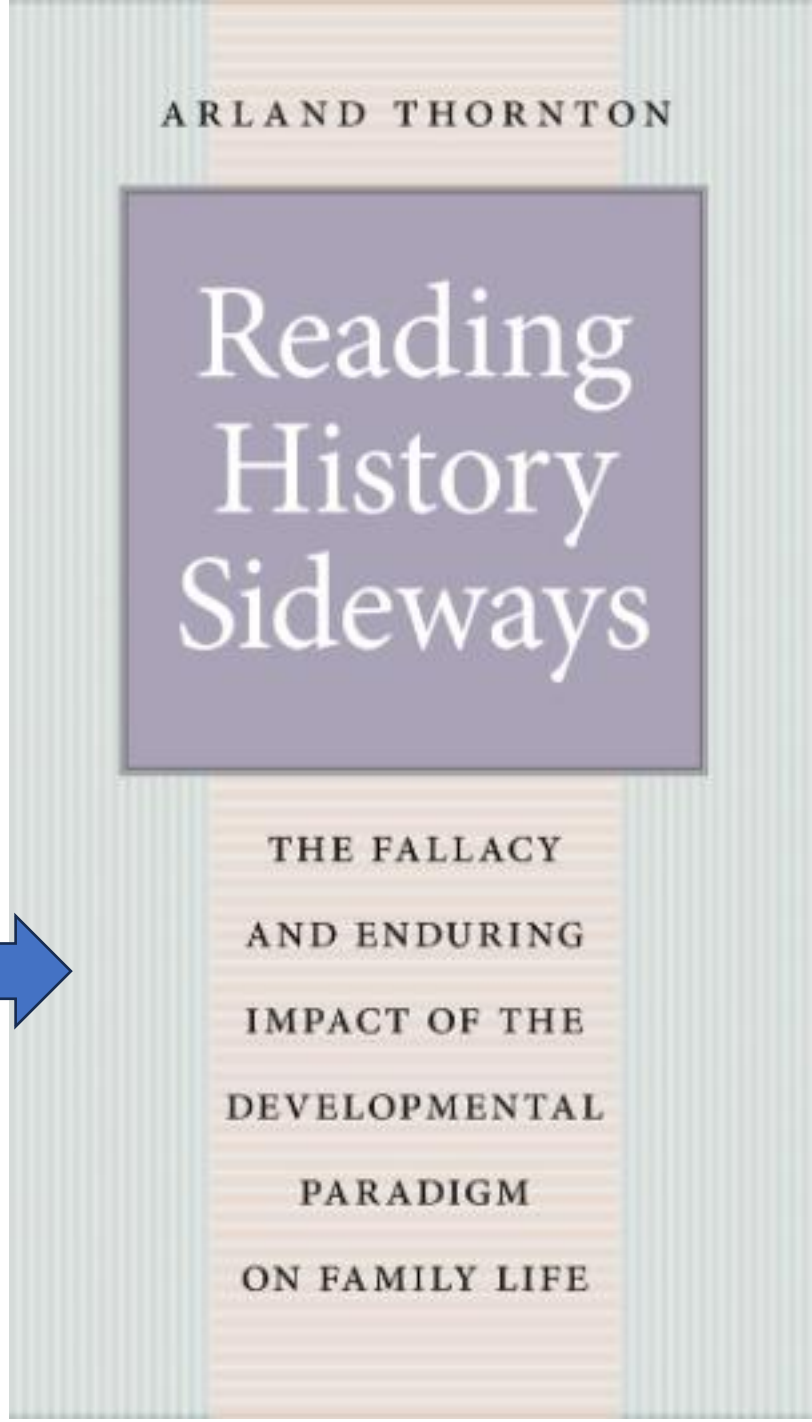
  - SDT = a set of changes associated with higher levels of development
  - Connections between demography and social phenomena
  - But danger of "reading history sideways"
    - "*future* evolution is proposed based on a single and *static* cross-sectional pattern"
    - Can we look at changes in one country and assume others will follow the same pattern? Is it universal?



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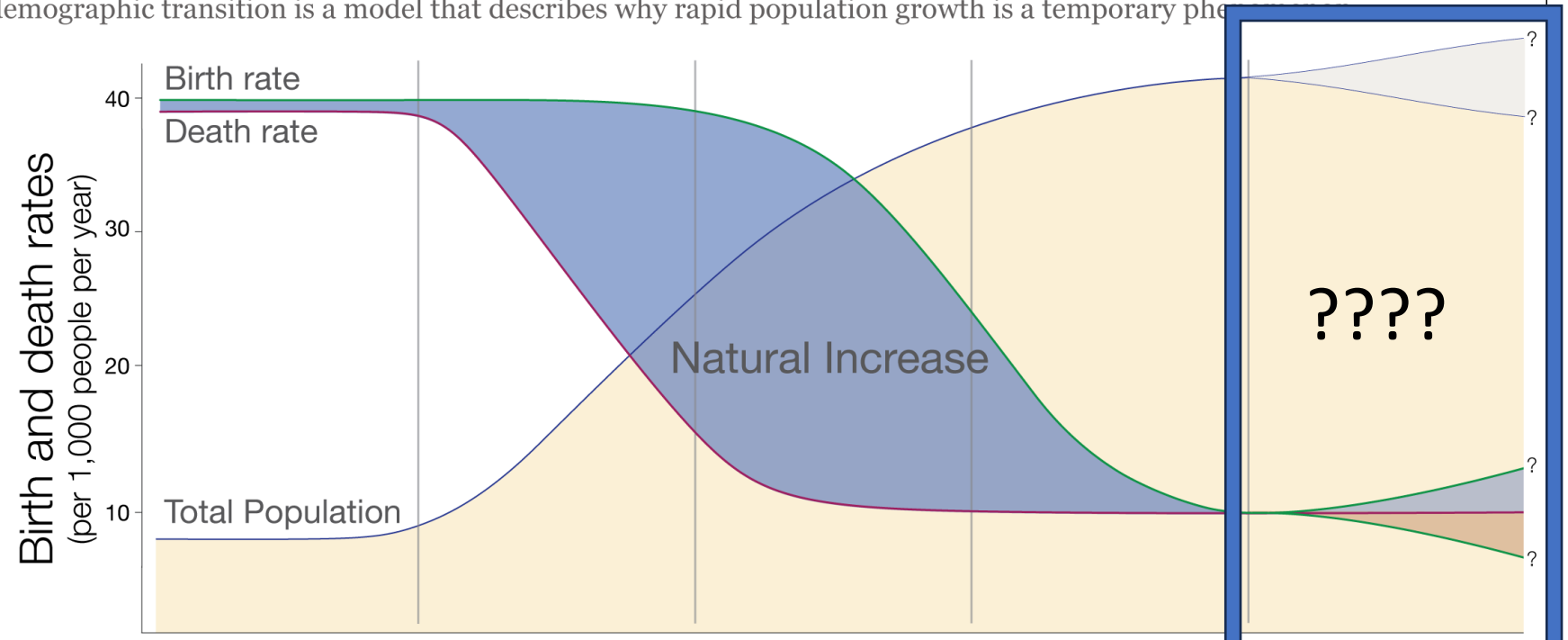


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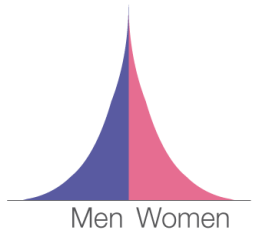
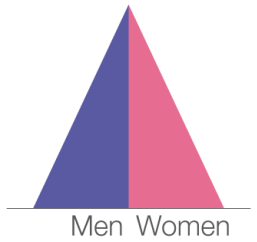
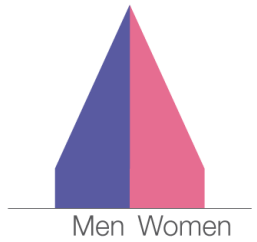
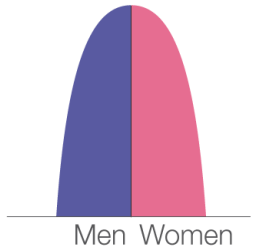
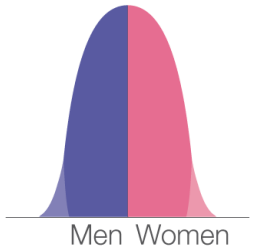
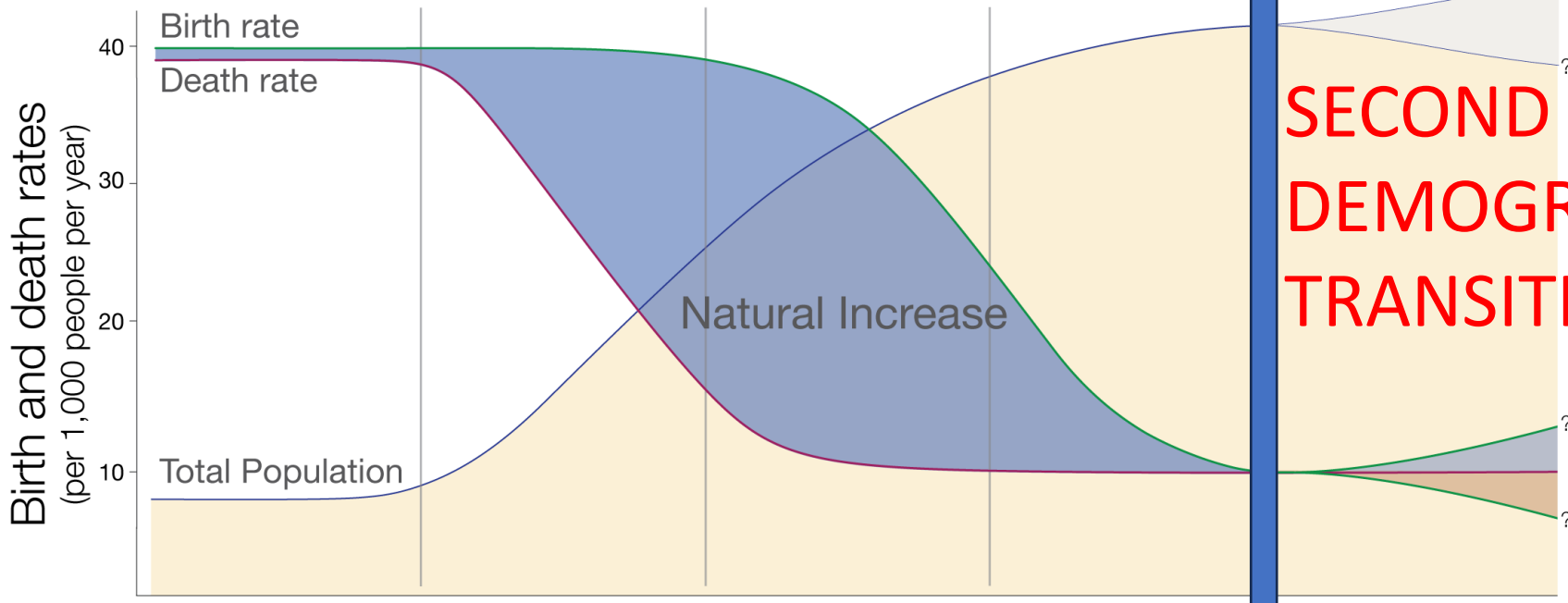
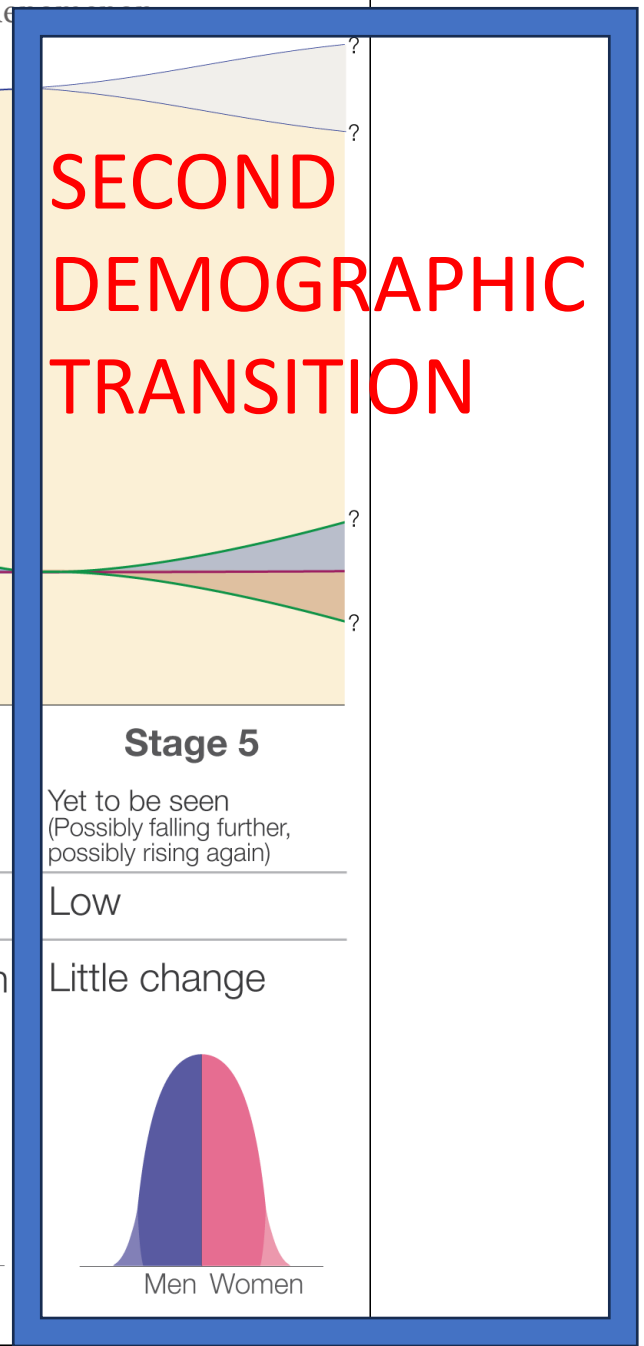
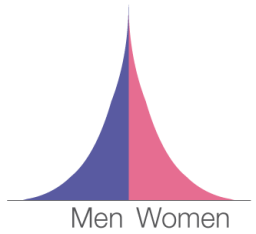
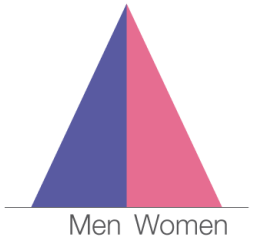
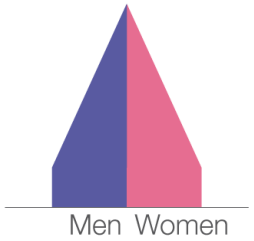
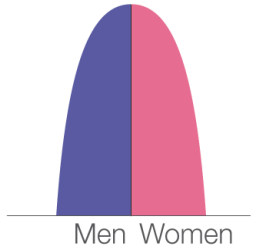
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

# The five stages of the demographic transition

The demographic transition is a model that describes why rapid population growth is a temporary phenomenon




| | Stage 1 | Stage 2 | Stage 3 | Stage 4 | Stage 5 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Birth rate | High | High | Falling | Low | Yet to be seen (Possibly falling further, possibly rising again) |
| Death rate | High | Falls rapidly | Falls more slowly | Low | Low |
| Natural increase | Stable or slow increase | Rapid increase | Increase slows down | Falling and then stable | Little change |
| Population Pyramid |  |  |  |  |  |

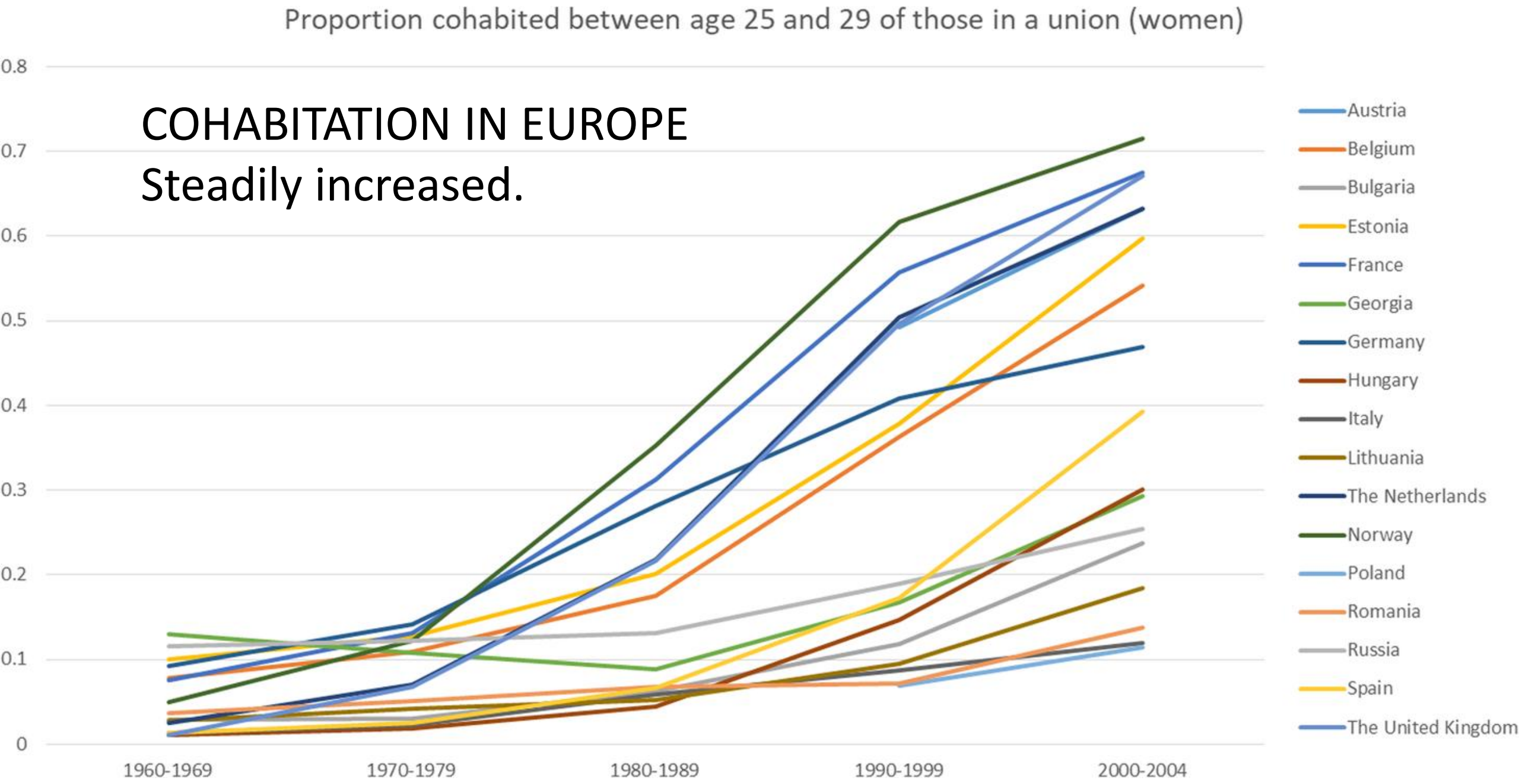
# Central Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition

(Van de Kaa 1987)

# Central Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition (Van de Kaa 1987)

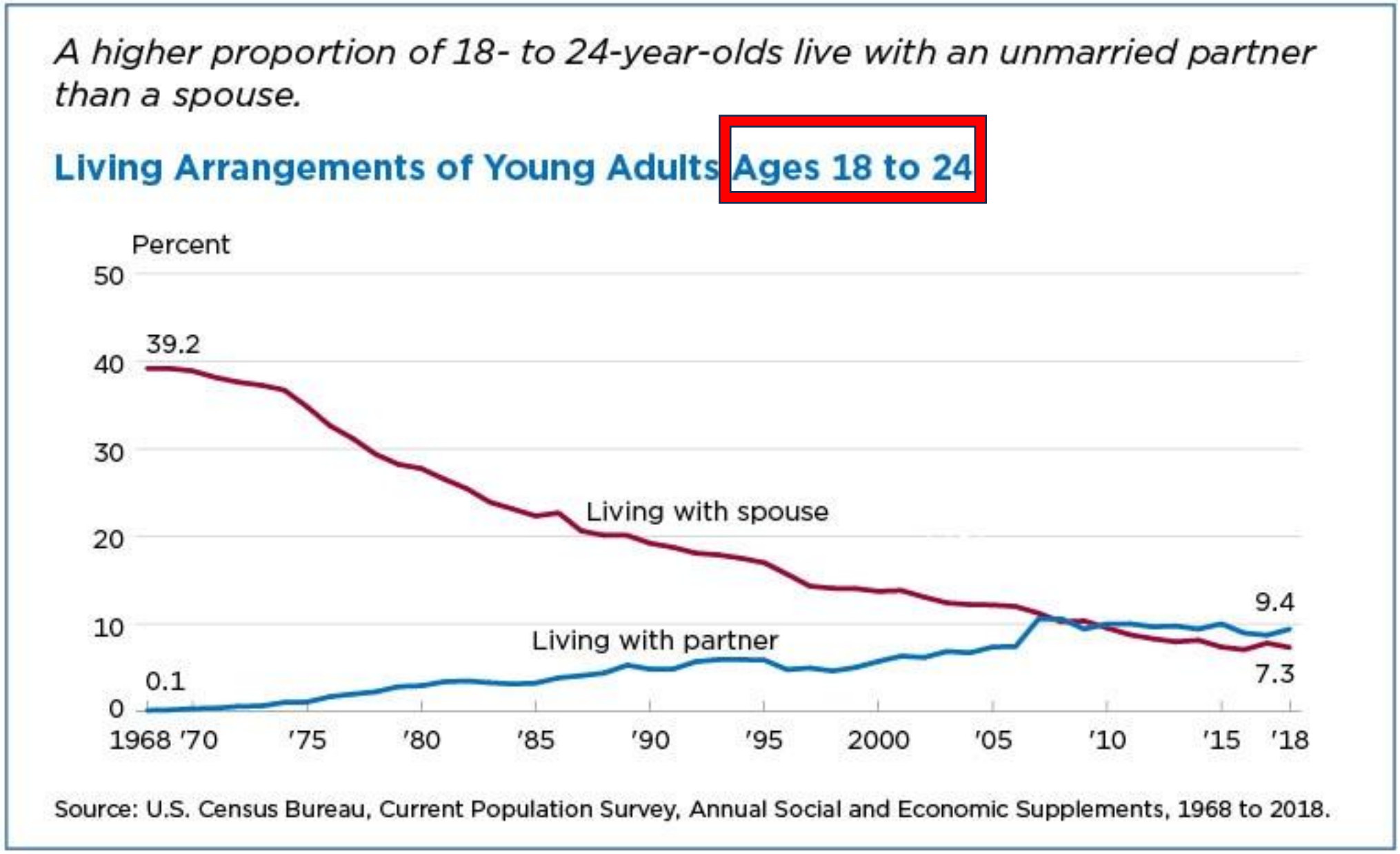
- The weakening of marriage as the only type of family structure
  - high divorce rates
  - rise in cohabitation

# COHABITATION IN EUROPE
Steadily increased.

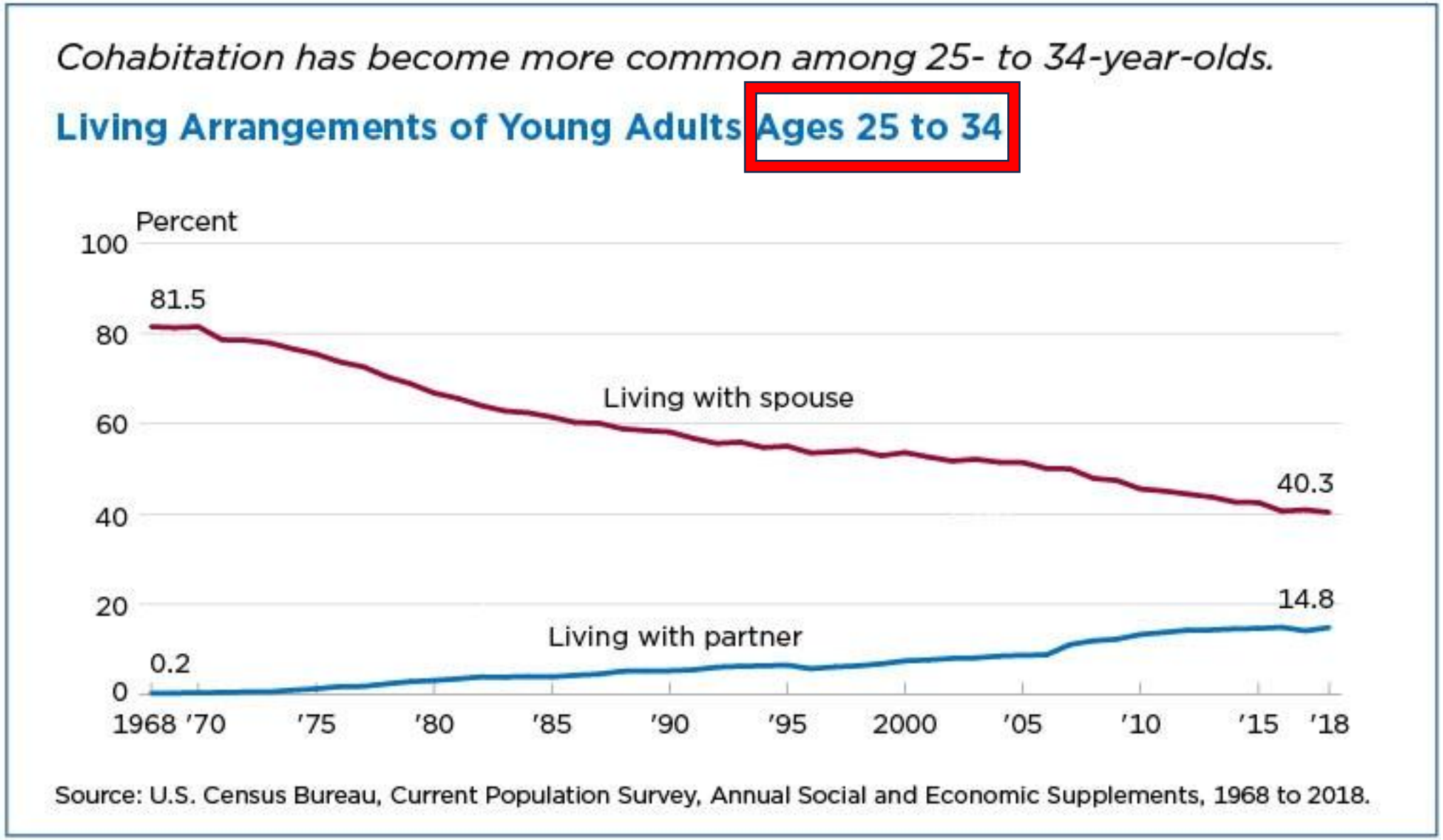


# USA

Cohab increased in USA too



# USA


Cohabitation has become more common among 25- to 34-year-olds.
Living Arrangements of Young Adults Ages 25 to 34
Percent
100
80
60
40
20
0
81.5
Living with spouse
40.3
14.8
Living with partner
0.2
1968 '70
'75
'80
'85
'90
'95
2000
'05
'10
'15
'18
Source: U.S. Census Bureau, Current Population Survey, Annual Social and Economic Supplements, 1968 to 2018.

# Basic Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition (Van de Kaa 1987)

- The weakening of marriage as the only type of family structure
- Shift in family relations from “king-child” with parents to “king-couple” with child

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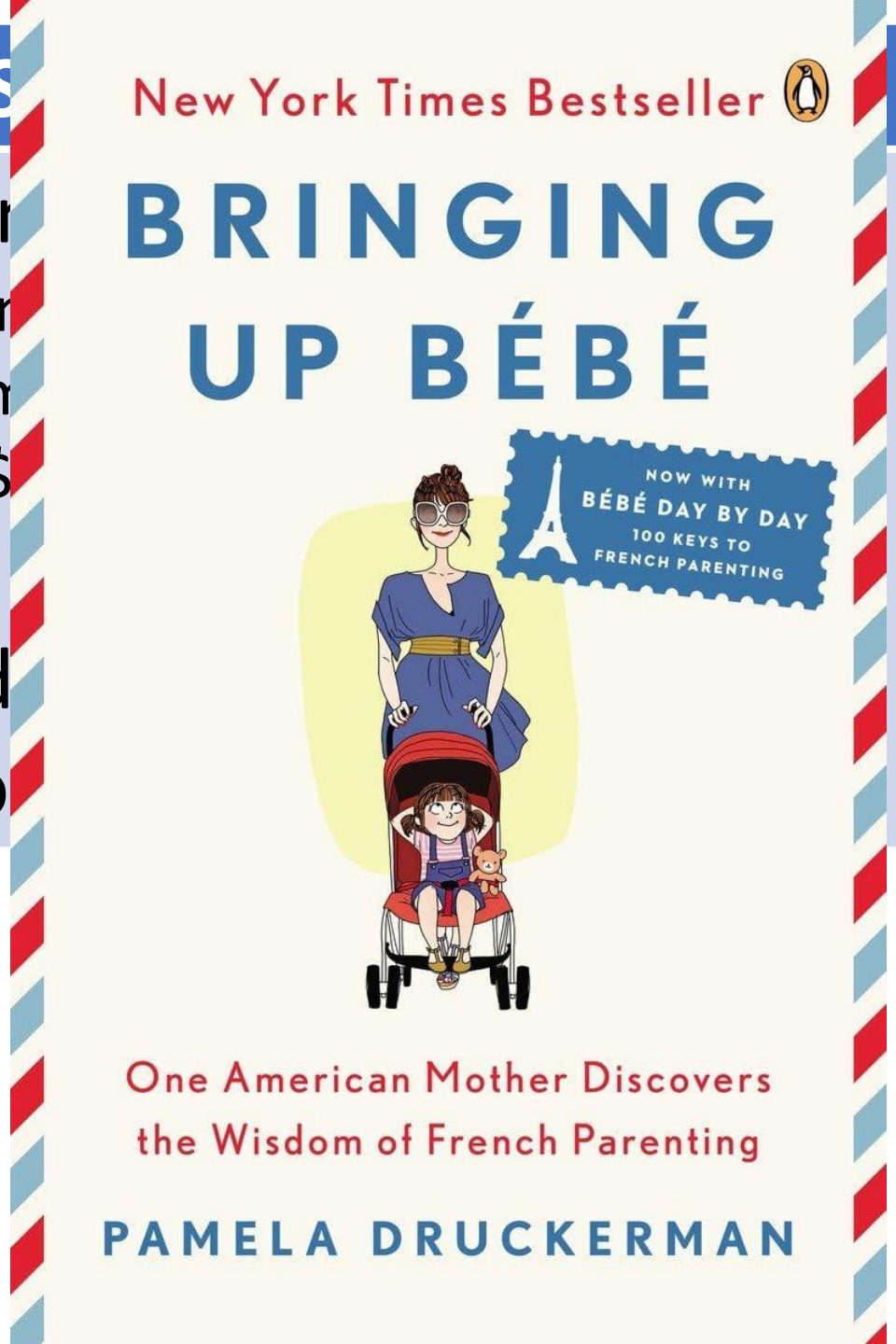
# Basic Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition (Van de Kaa 1987)

- The weakening of marriage as the only type of family structure
- Shift in family relations from “king-child” with parents to “king-couple” with child
  - Prioritize parent well-being
  - Limited family size not to move up the social ladder but for self-fulfillment.

| Pre-SDT | SDT |
| --- | --- |
| Parents sacrifice for children<br>• Time<br>• Employment<br>• $$<br><br>Children's outcomes improve beyond parents' | |

| Pre-SDT | SDT |
| --- | --- |
| Parents sacrifice for children<br>• Time<br>• Employment<br>• $$<br><br>Children's outcomes improve beyond parents' | Parents weigh their own interests with those of their children<br><br>Children are intrinsically rewarding |

| Pre-S | | SDT |
|---|---|---|
| Paren<br>• Tir<br>• Em<br>• $$<br><br>Child<br>beyo | | Parents weigh their own interests with those of their children<br><br>Children are intrinsically rewarding |



# Basic Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition (Van de Kaa 1987)

- The weakening of marriage as the only type of family structure
- Shift in family relations from king-child with parents to king-couple with child
- A shift from preventive contraception to self-fulfilling contraception
  - Not just prevent unwanted births, but to have children as an expression of self fulfilment

# Maslow's hierarchy of needs

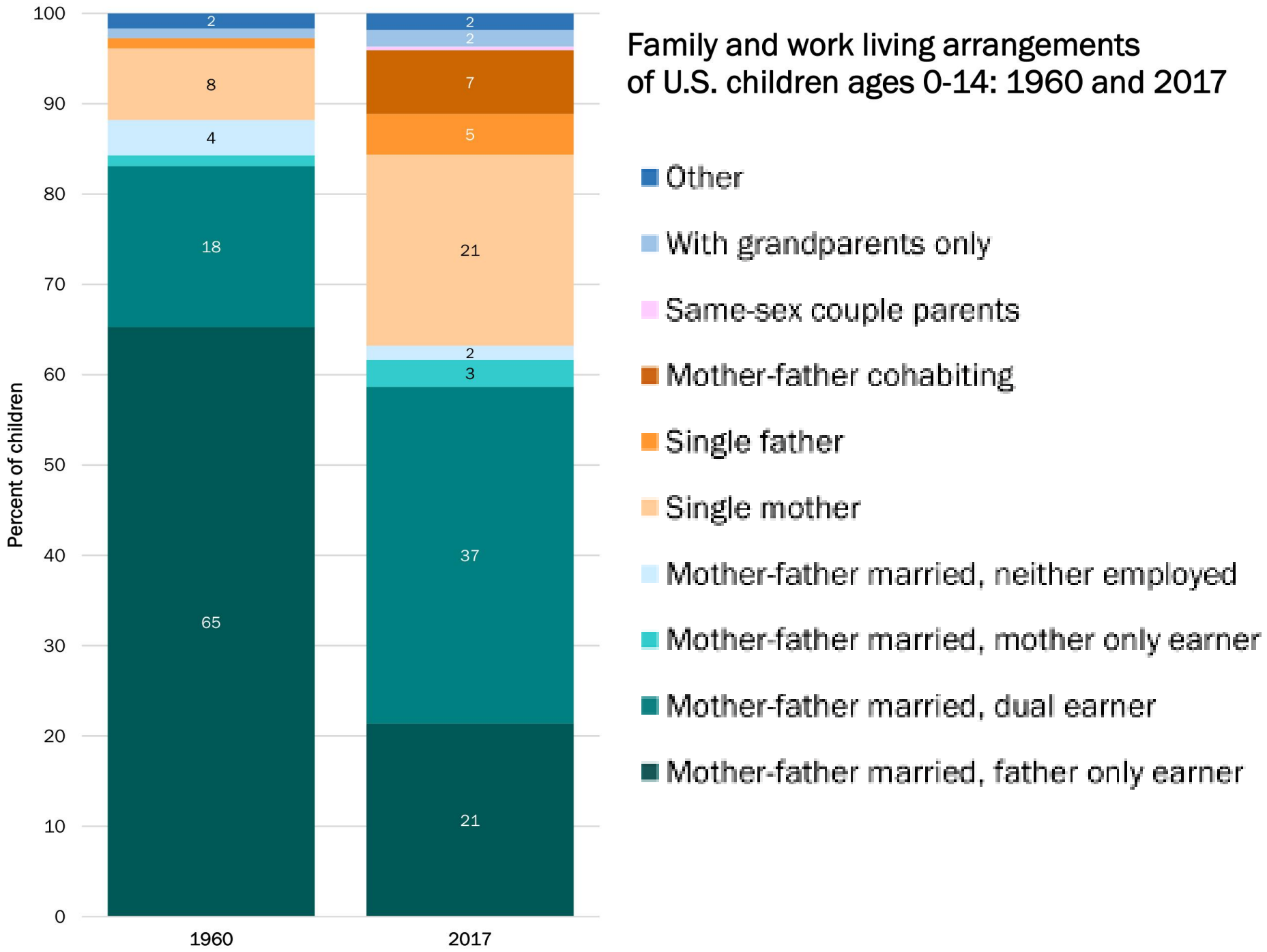
# Maslow's hierarchy of needs

2nd Demographic Transition is about these

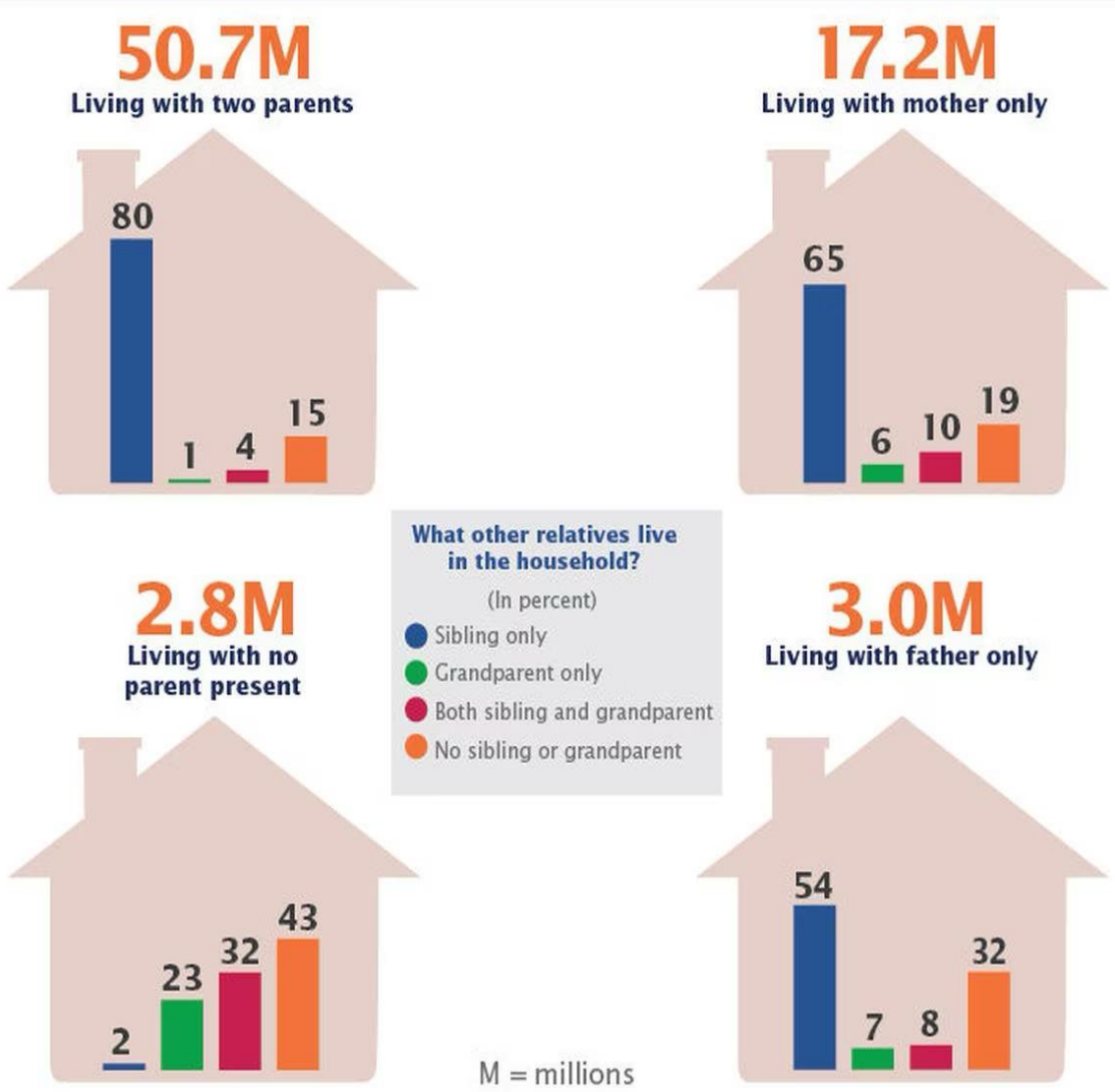
Maslow's hierarchy of needs

# Basic Components of the 2nd Demographic Transition (Van de Kaa 1987)

- The weakening of marriage as the only type of family structure, resulting from high divorce rates and a rise in cohabitation
- Shift in family relations from king-child with parents to king-couple with child
- A shift from preventive contraception to self-fulfilling contraception
- The uniform family (the conjugal family) starts giving way to more pluralistic forms of families


Family and work living arrangements of U.S. children ages 0-14: 1960 and 2017
Percent of children
100
90
80
70
60
50
40
30
20
10
0
1960
2017
2
8
4
18
65
2
2
7
5
21
2
3
37
21
Other
With grandparents only
Same-sex couple parents
Mother-father cohabiting
Single father
Single mother
Mother-father married, neither employed
Mother-father married, mother only earner
Mother-father married, dual earner
Mother-father married, father only earner

# Living Arrangements of Children Under Age 18



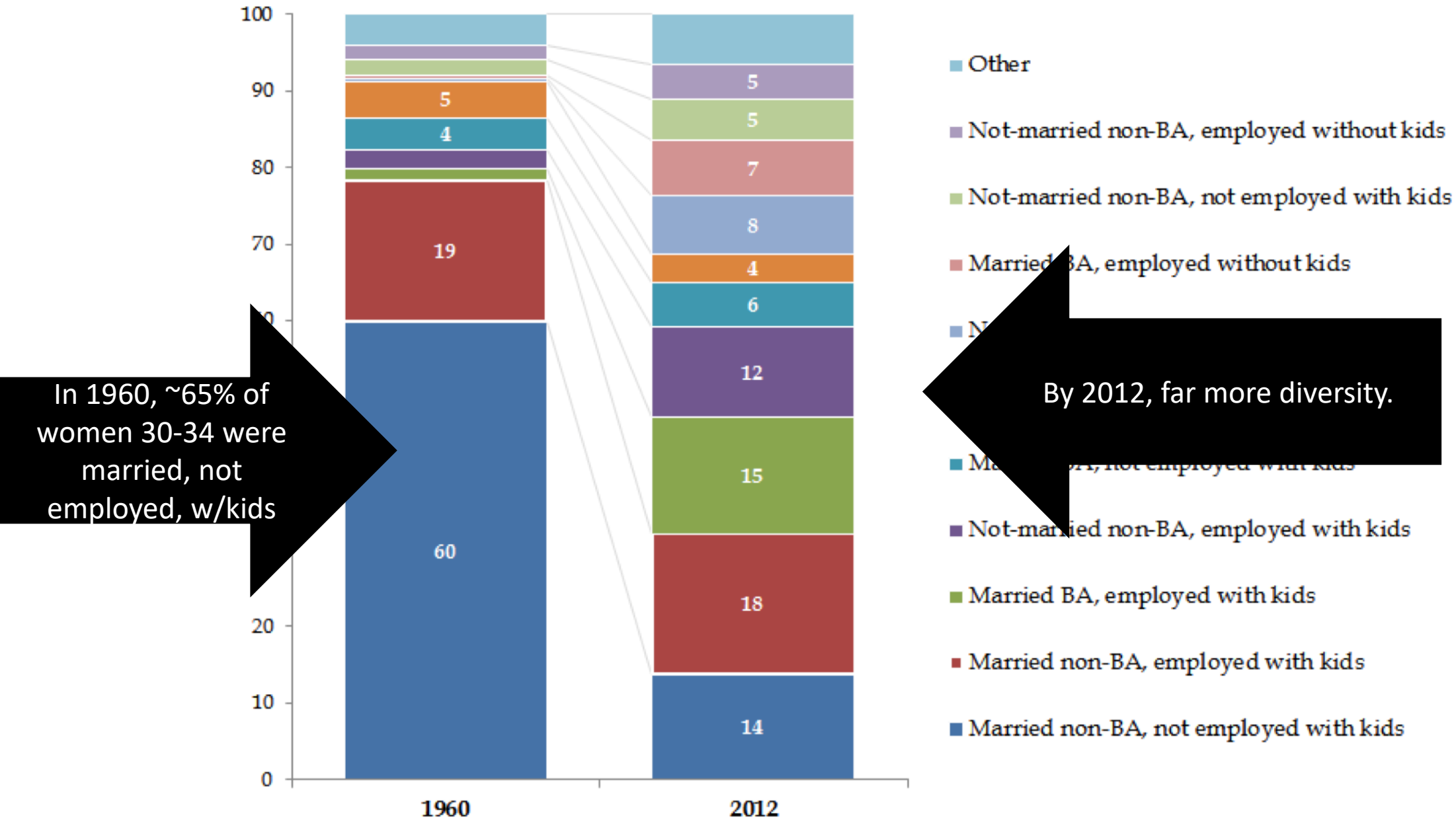

United States Census Bureau | U.S. Department of Commerce Economics and Statistics Administration U.S. CENSUS BUREAU census.gov

Source: 2016 Current Population Survey Annual Social and Economic Supplement
www.census.gov/hhes/families/

# Educational, Employment, Marital and Parental Status: Women Ages 30-34, 1960 & 2012

In 1960, ~65% of women 30-34 were married, not employed, w/kids

# Educational, Employment, Marital and Parental Status: Women Ages 30-34, 1960 & 2012



# Why is the SDT not just a continuation of the first?

- The **focal phenomenon** changed
  - it was no longer just number of kids, but rather timing and *motivations*

- Shift in norms, from altruistic to individualistic
- Individual autonomy was more central, particularly for women

# Questions of the day

https://tinyurl.com/170soc29

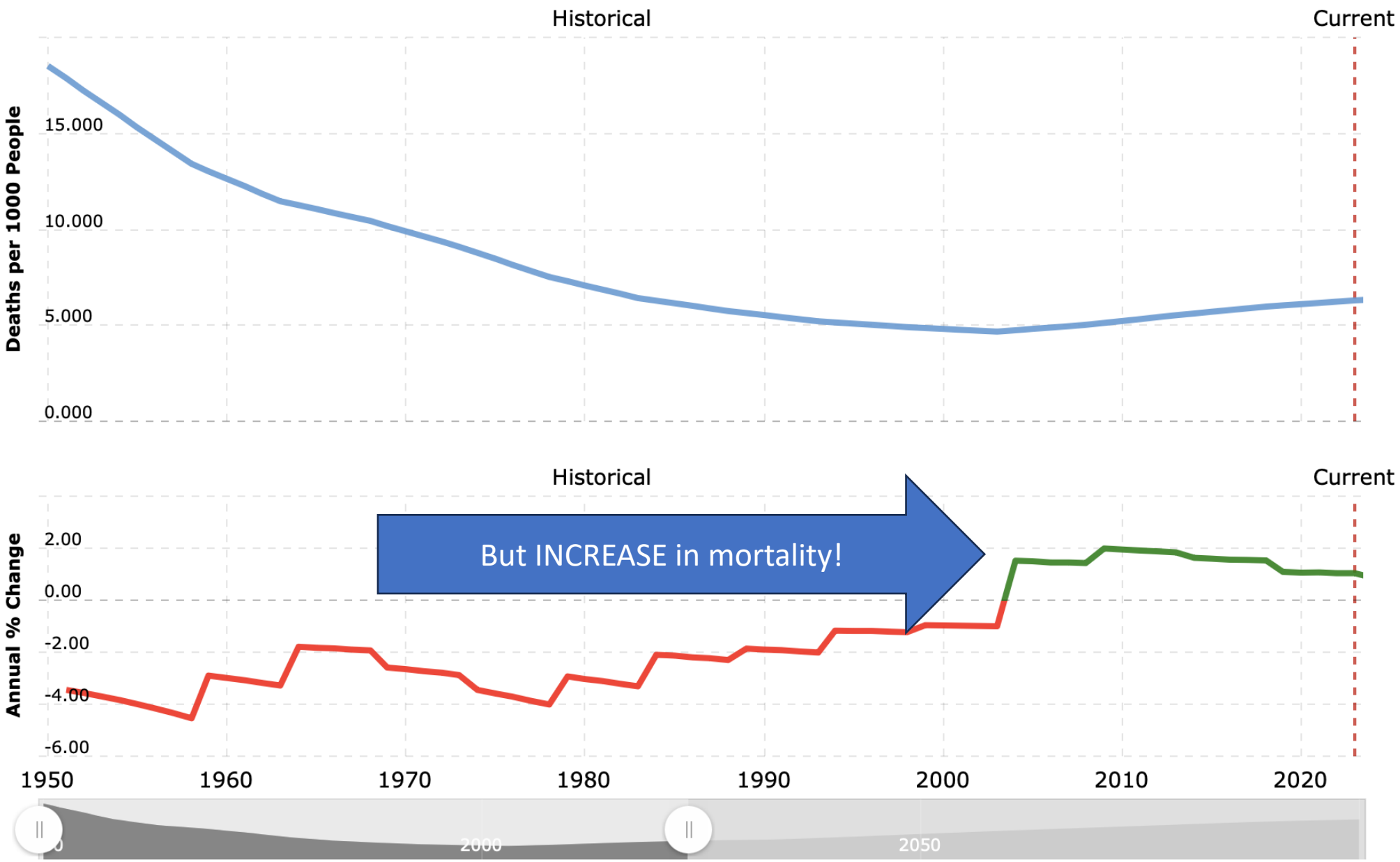
Do you think the 2nd Demographic transition is over in the US? Why or why not?

# So, is the SDT for everyone?

# Mexico

Recent decline in fertility

# Mexico Mortality



# Mexico

Increase in divorce rates

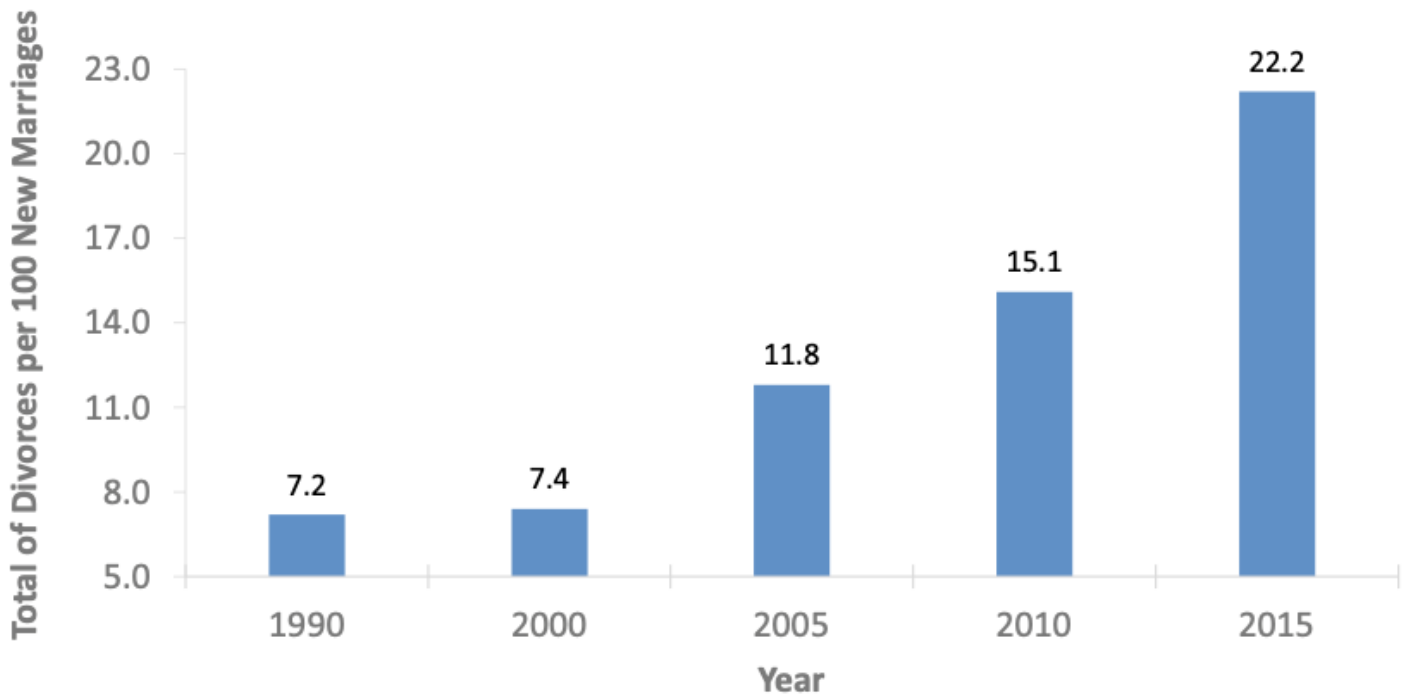


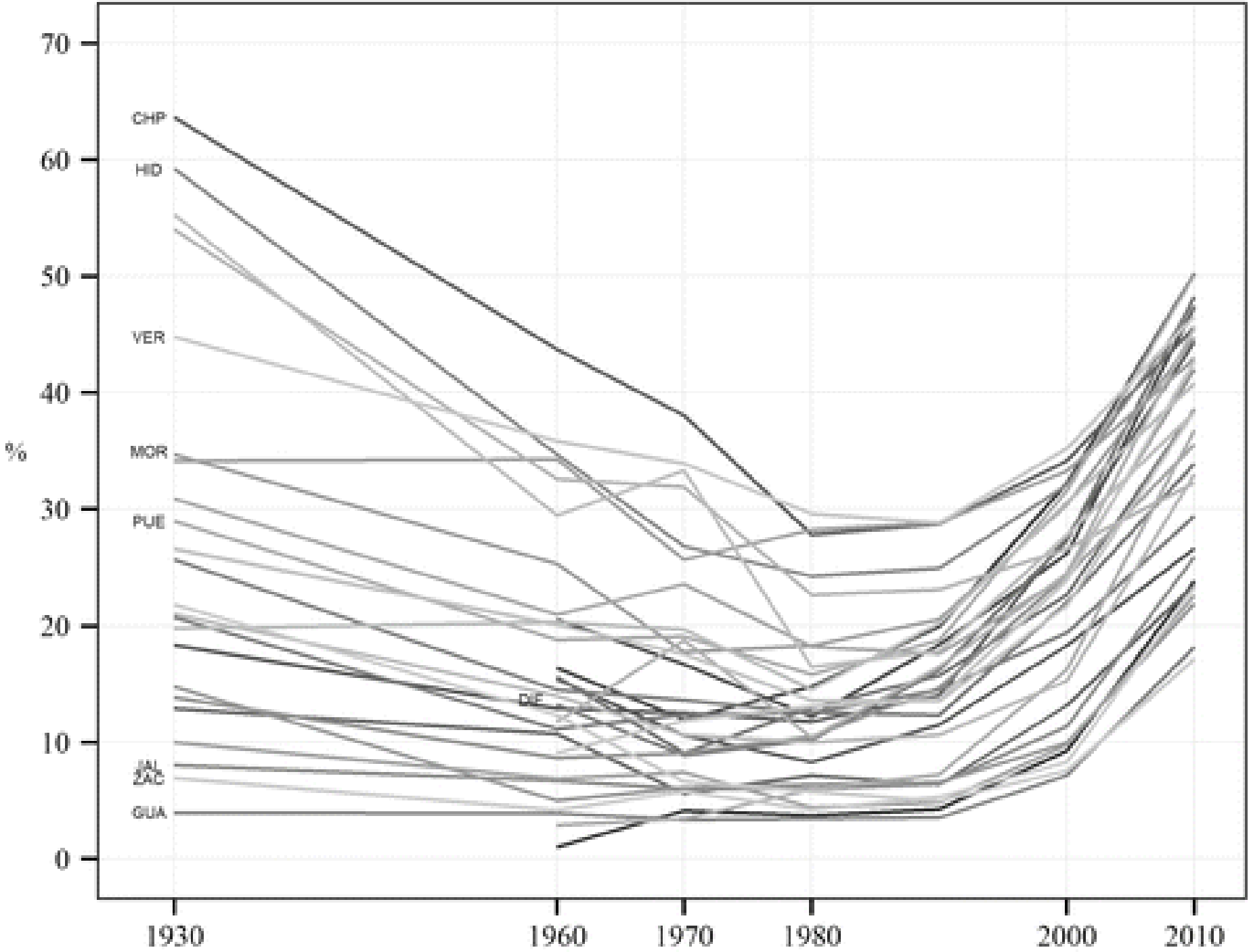

**Fig. 2** Divorces per 100 new marriages in Mexico (Source: National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI))

# Mexico

- Percent cohabiting among women 25–29 in a union, Mexican states 1930–2010

(*Source*: Esteve et al. 2016)

And increase in cohabitation

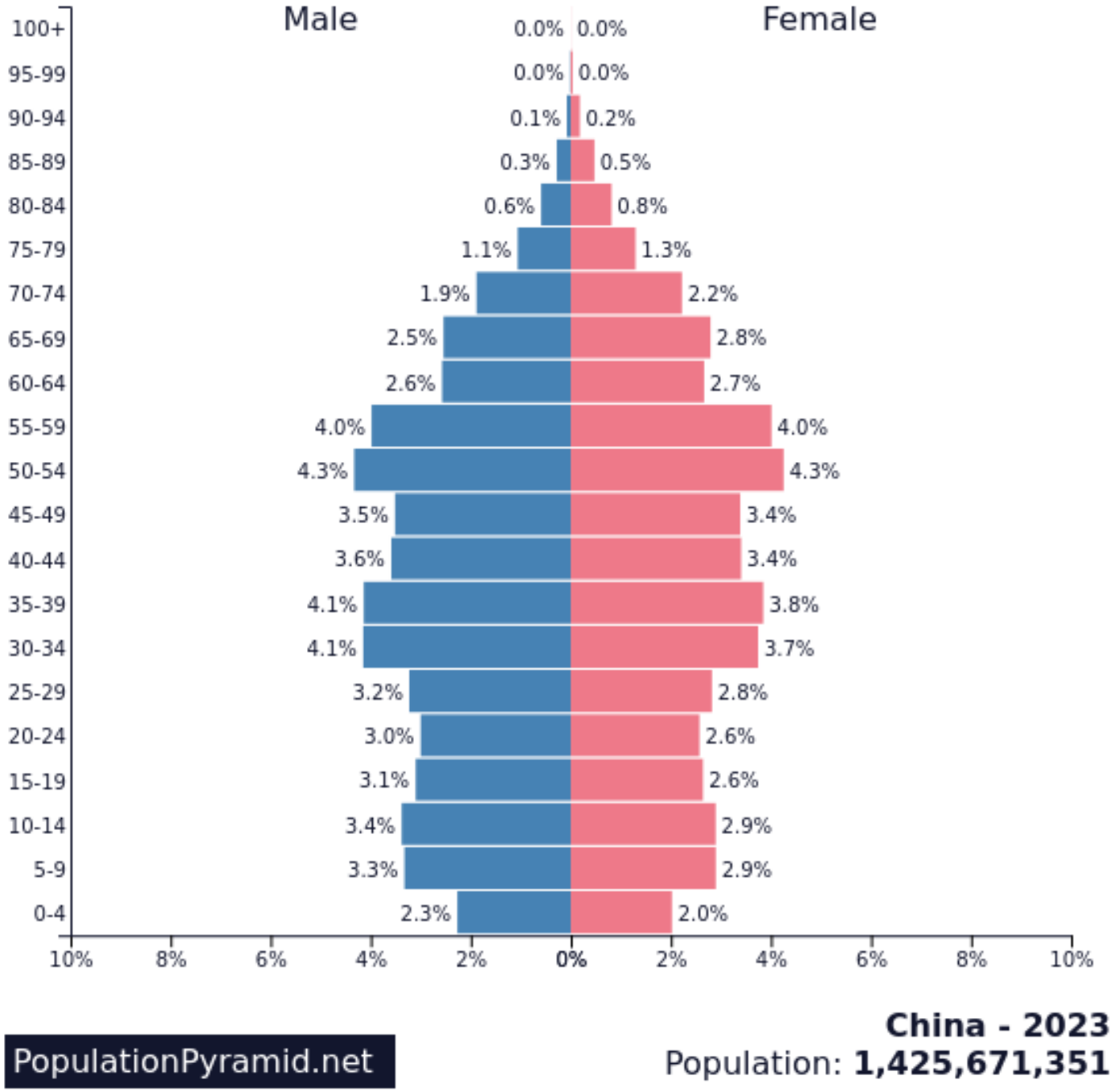


# Mexico

- By *why* do we see these changes?
- Harder to answer…

# China

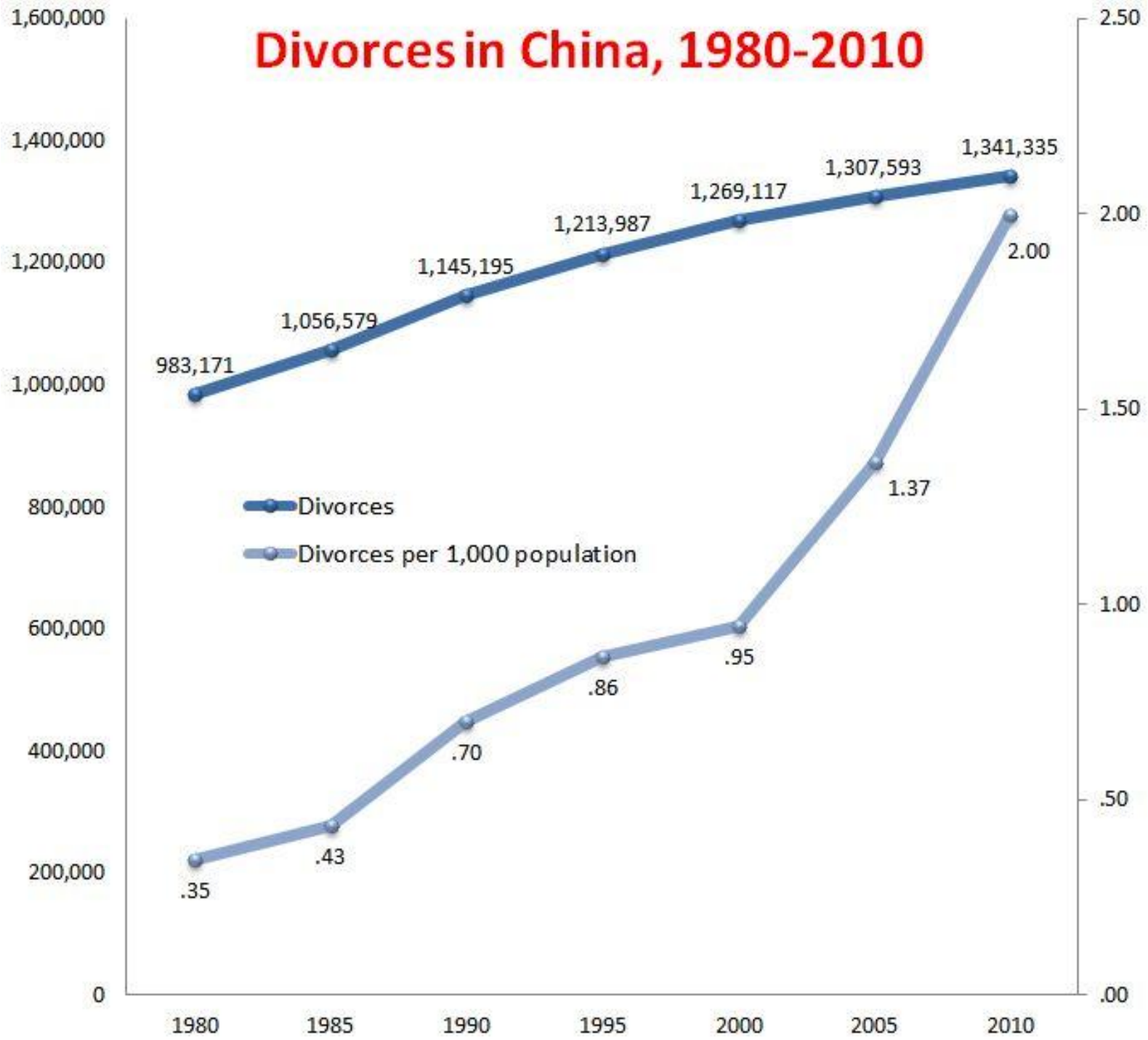
Declining fertility


Male
Female
100+ 0.0% 0.0%
95-99 0.0% 0.0%
90-94 0.1% 0.2%
85-89 0.3% 0.5%
80-84 0.6% 0.8%
75-79 1.1% 1.3%
70-74 1.9% 2.2%
65-69 2.5% 2.8%
60-64 2.6% 2.7%
55-59 4.0% 4.0%
50-54 4.3% 4.3%
45-49 3.5% 3.4%
40-44 3.6% 3.4%
35-39 4.1% 3.8%
30-34 4.1% 3.7%
25-29 3.2% 2.8%
20-24 3.0% 2.6%
15-19 3.1% 2.6%
10-14 3.4% 2.9%
5-9 3.3% 2.9%
0-4 2.3% 2.0%
10% 8% 6% 4% 2% 0% 2% 4% 6% 8% 10%
PopulationPyramid.net
China - 2023
Population: 1,425,671,351

# China

Source: Cohen 2011

Increase in divorce rates



# China

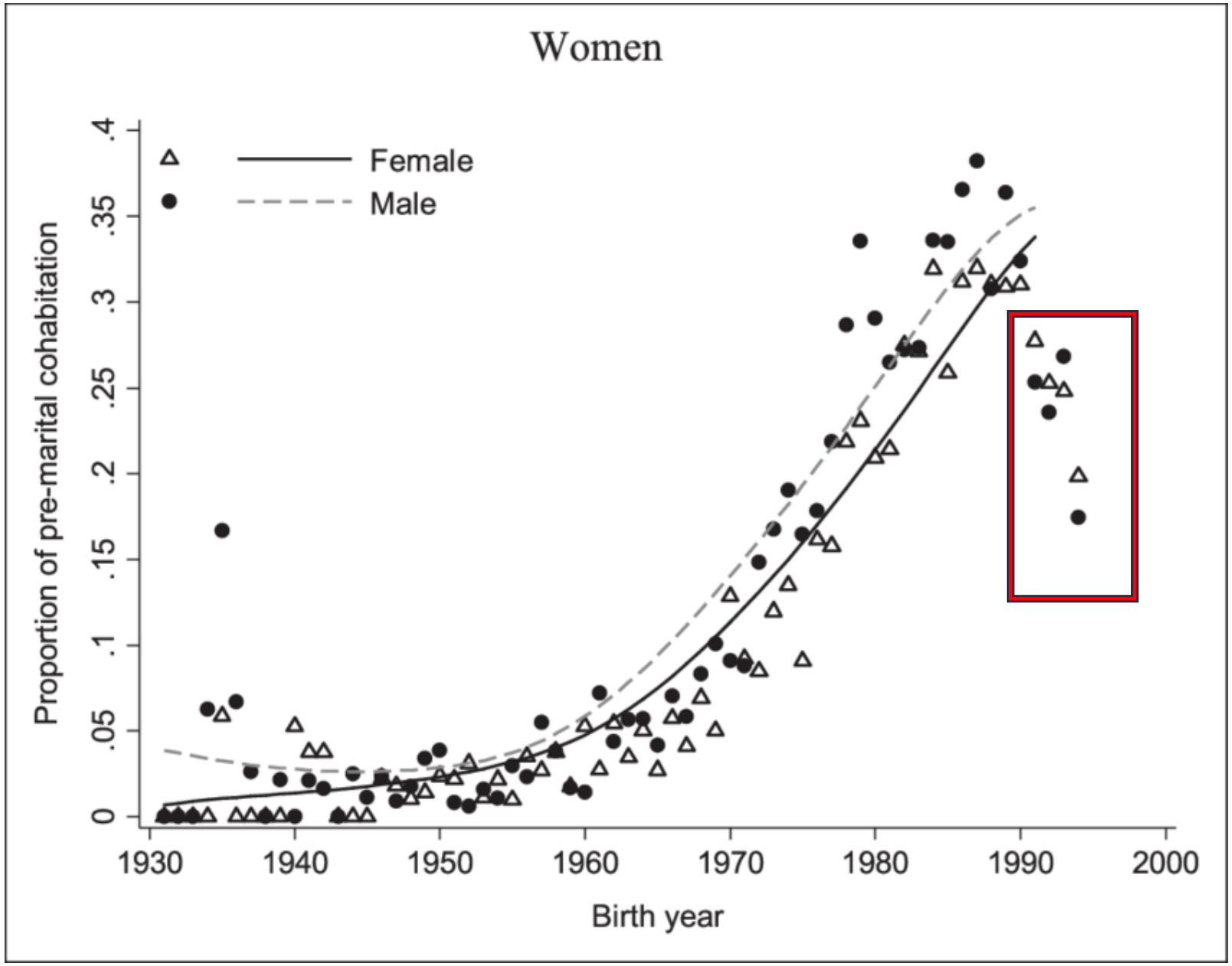
Big increase in cohabitation!

But then a drop?

Two explanations for recent dropoff :

1) Younger cohorts not cohabiting
2) Younger cohorts cohabiting later

Source: Yu 2021



# China

Little change in attitudes about divorce.

Source: Yu and Xie 2022

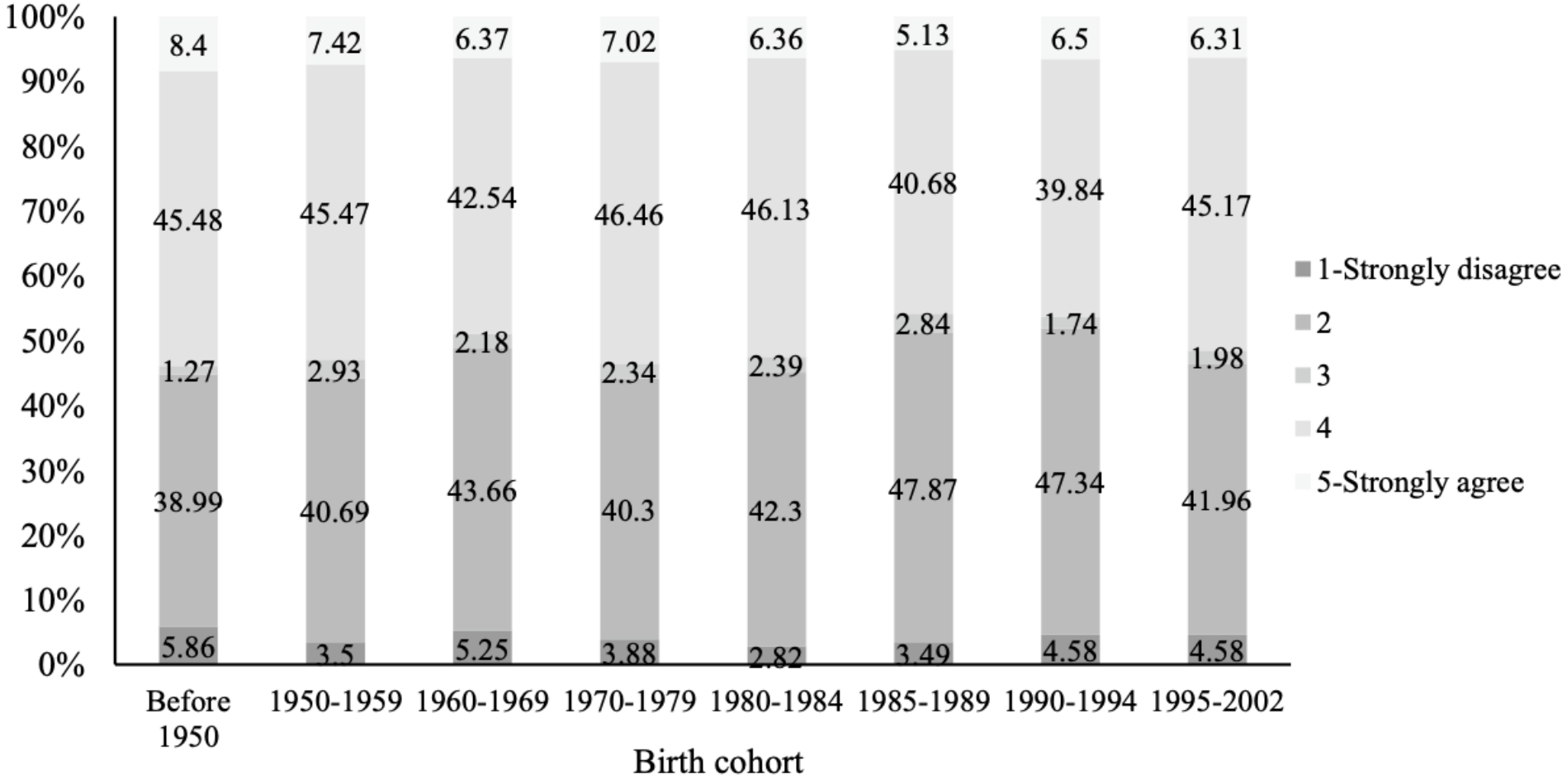



**Fig. 8** Attitudes toward "For the sake of the children, parents should not divorce despite an unhappy marriage" by birth cohort. Data sources: China Family Panel Studies 2020

# China

But big shift in attitudes about motherhood

Source: Yu and Xie 2022

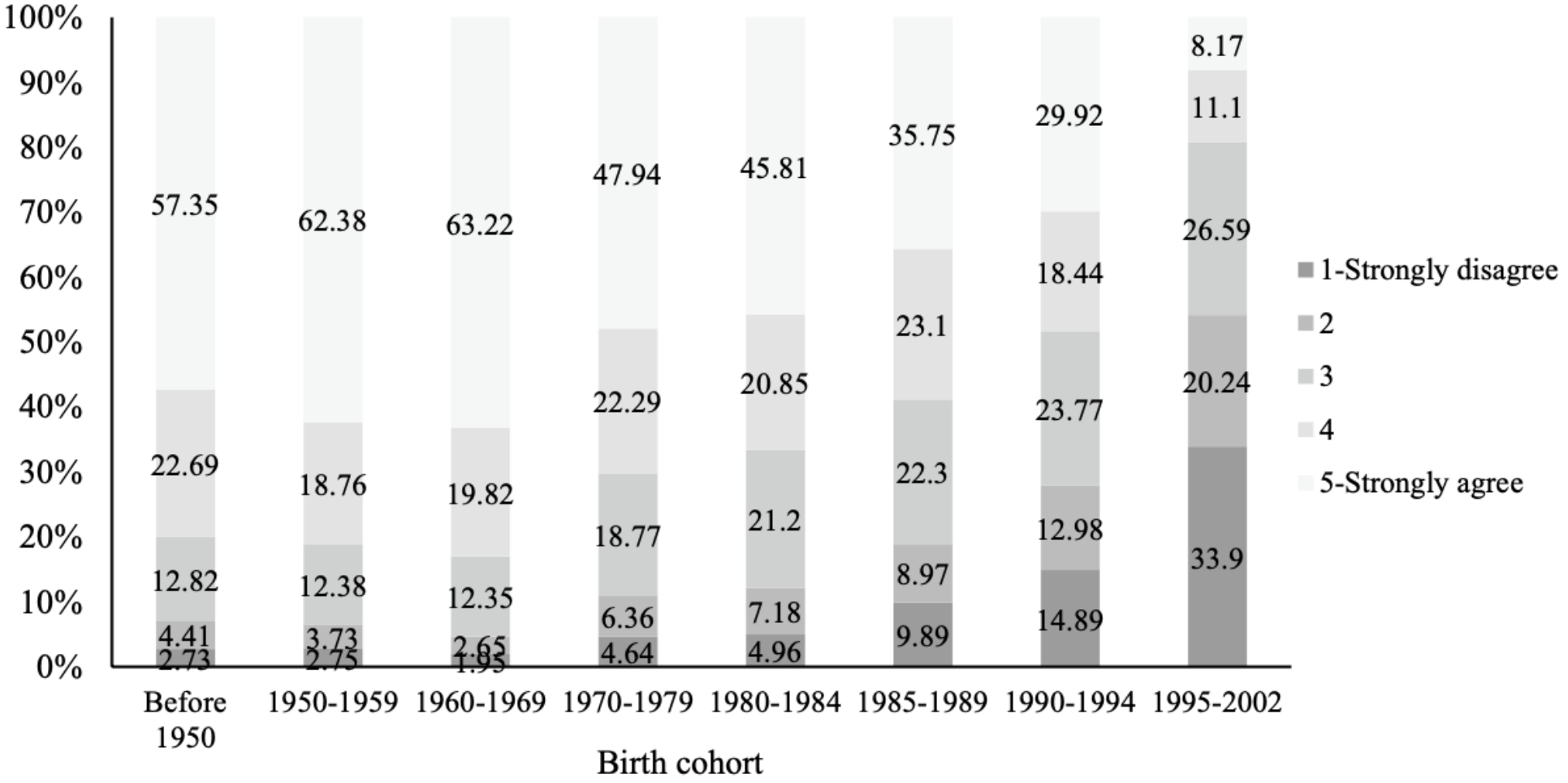
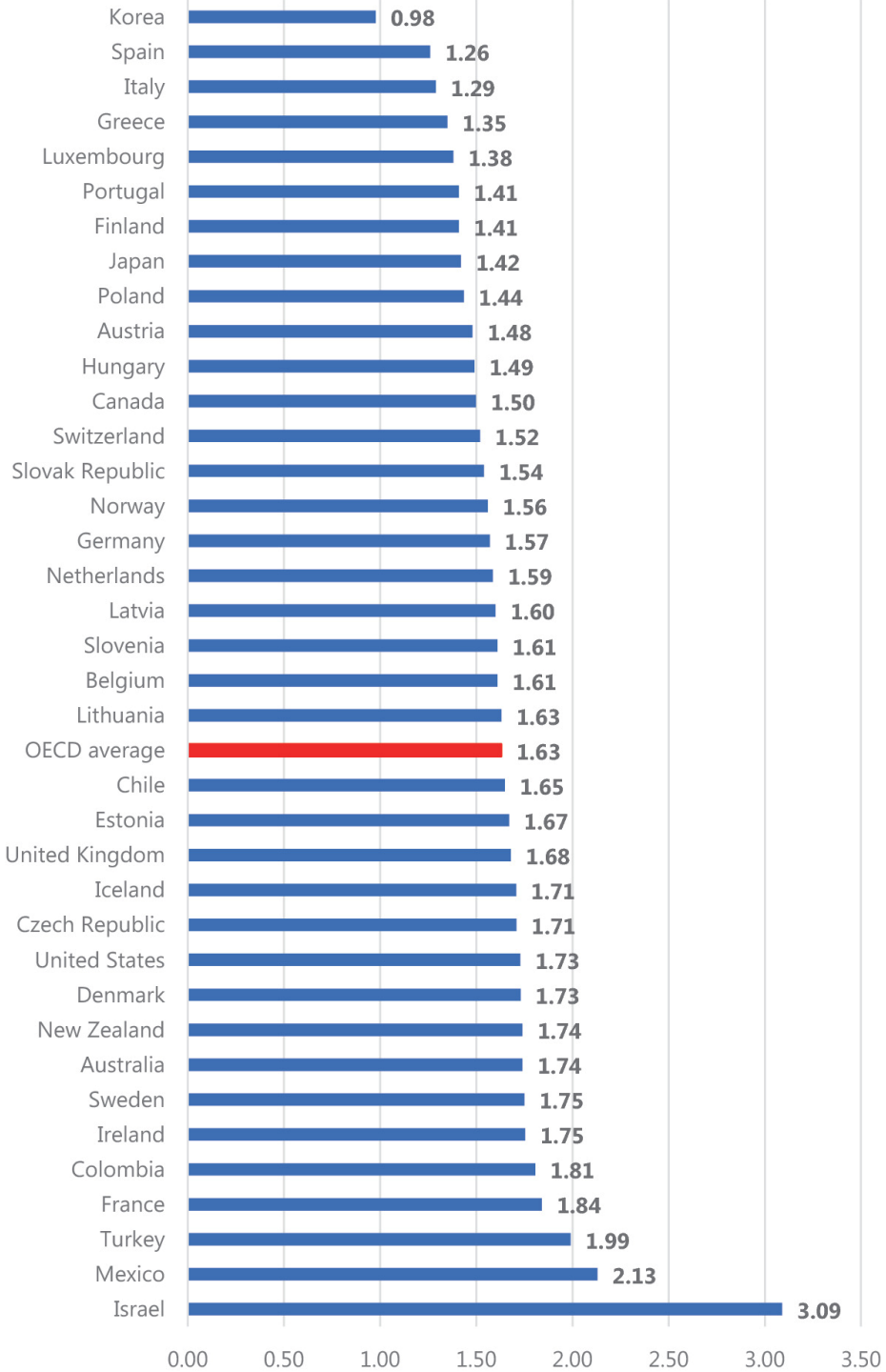
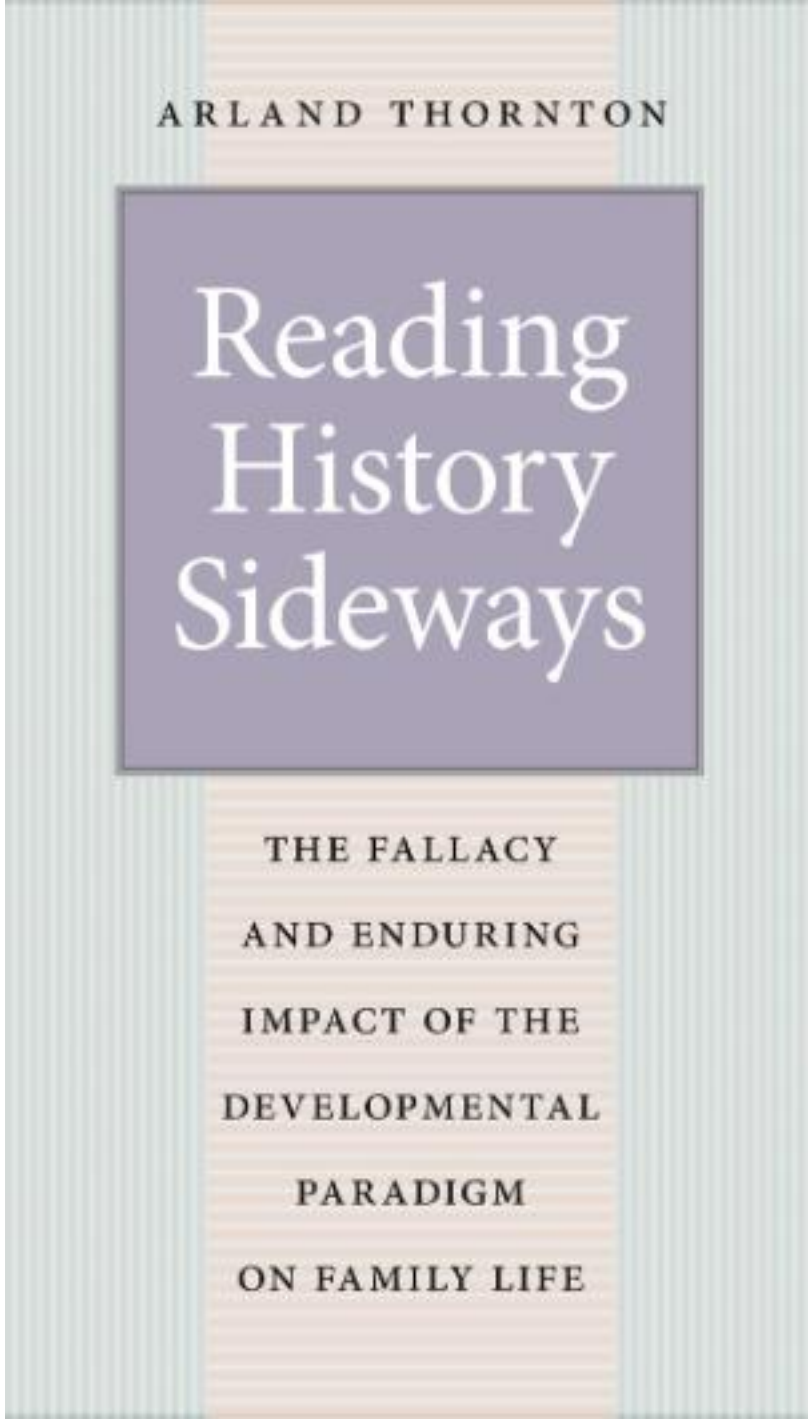



**Fig. 12** Attitudes toward "motherhood makes a woman complete" by birth cohort among chinese women. Data sources: China Family Panel Studies 2020

# Fertility Rates OECD, 2018

- Lots of variation, even among rich countries.



# Reading History Sideways?

- Don’t throw out the SDT – it describes important patterns in a lot of places
- But don’t assume that a theory that is good in one type of society is good everywhere!